The Archer and the Wind

Hard Work, Luck, Destiny, and the Hope That Holds Them Together

Muhammad Waqas

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The Archer and the Wind: Hard Work, Luck, Destiny, and the Hope That Holds Them Together

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The people in the illustrative stories in this book are composites. Their names are invented and any resemblance to real individuals is coincidental. The studies, historical events and quotations are real, and their sources are listed in the Notes at the end of the book.

This book offers reflection, not professional advice. If disappointment has turned into despair, please speak to someone you trust or to a qualified professional.

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For everyone who did everything right
and still did not get what they wanted.

You were not foolish to try.

Suppose a man makes it his purpose to hit a mark with a spear or an arrow. All he can do is everything to aim straight. And still, the actual hitting of the mark is, as the Stoics put it, "to be chosen, not to be desired."

Paraphrased from Cicero, *On Ends*, Book III

In the fields of observation, chance favors only the prepared mind.

Louis Pasteur, lecture at Lille, 1854

Introduction: Four words I could not put down

For most of my adult life I have been carrying on an argument with four words.

Hard work. Luck. Destiny. Hope.

I could add a fifth, because for many of us hope has an older and more serious form, and its name is prayer. Hope is what you feel at night about tomorrow. Prayer is what you say about it, out loud or in silence, to whoever you believe is listening.

They are ordinary words. Children learn them early. We use them at weddings and funerals, in job interviews and hospital corridors, on the night before an exam and the morning after a rejection. Parents hand them to their children like heirlooms. Work hard. Pray. Don't lose hope. What is written is written.

And yet, inside my own head, these four words have never once agreed with each other.

I noticed the first thing so many times that I eventually stopped calling it coincidence. When I worked hard, my luck seemed to work hard too. When I prepared properly for something, the right question came up. When I put in the hours, the right person happened to walk past at the right moment. I am not talking about miracles. I am talking about the small, suspi-

cious kindnesses of timing that seem to arrive more often for people who are already moving. You have probably noticed it as well. There is an old line that says the harder you work, the luckier you get, and it survives because so many people have felt it to be true.

Then I noticed the second thing, and it did not fit the first at all.

I watched people do everything right and lose.

I have seen people prepare for years for a single job, study the company, rehearse every answer, pray before the interview and walk out knowing they had given their best, only to receive a short, polite email a week later. I have seen people love someone with their whole heart, build a future with that person in their imagination brick by brick, pray for it every night, and then watch that future go to somebody else. These were not lazy people. They were not careless people. They did not lack faith or hope. They had more of both than most.

There is a song by Linkin Park called “In the End” that a whole generation once shouted along to in their bedrooms and their cars. Its chorus is a confession: all that trying, all that distance covered, and at the end none of it seemed to count. It is easy to dismiss a rock song. But I have noticed that people tend to quote that chorus at exactly the moment when they have stopped believing in something they once believed in completely. It is the sound of a promise breaking.

So the questions began, and they would not leave.

If our destiny is already written, and we will receive what we were always going to receive, then what is the point of working so hard? What is the point of praying? Why build hopes at all, if the ending is already in the book?

But if we receive what we work for, if effort really does decide the outcome, then what is destiny for? Why do some people work themselves to the bone and get nothing, while others stroll into the very thing they barely wanted?

And if luck is the real master here, if it is all a roll of the dice, then why does it seem to favor people who prepare?

I would think my way to one side of the argument, and then life would push me back to the other. I would decide that effort was everything, and then I would watch a good man fail. I would decide that everything was written, and then I would watch someone's sheer stubbornness change the shape of their life. I would decide that hope was foolish, and then I would meet someone whose hope was the only reason they were still standing.

Maybe you know this feeling. Maybe it is why you picked up this book.

* * *

What I slowly understood is that these four words are more than ideas. They are pillars. People build their whole lives on one or another of them, often without realizing they have chosen.

Some people stand on the pillar of hard work. Their creed is effort, discipline, early mornings, no excuses. They are admirable, and they get a great deal done, and they are often merciless with themselves when the results do not come, because in their system a bad result can only mean one thing: you did not work hard enough.

Some people stand on the pillar of luck. They have seen enough of the world's unfairness to stop believing in the neat story. They are often wise about how much is out of our hands, and they are often tempted to stop reaching for anything at all.

Some people stand on the pillar of destiny. What is meant for you will find you; what is not was never yours. This belief can give enormous peace. It can also, if held in the wrong way, become a beautiful excuse for not trying, or a cage that keeps someone waiting for years at a door that has already closed.

And some people stand on the pillar of hope and prayer. They have learned that the future is not finished, and they lean toward it with their whole hearts. They are often the bravest people in the room. They are also the ones who are hurt the most when the answer is no.

Each of these pillars holds up part of the truth. The trouble starts when we try to live on only one of them. A life built on effort alone turns cruel when effort fails. A life built on luck alone turns passive. A life built on destiny alone can turn into waiting. A life built on hope alone can turn into fantasy.

This book is my attempt to get all four words to sit at the same table and talk to each other. I want to know how they fit together, because I am convinced they do.

* * *

Long before any of us were born, philosophers in Athens and Rome were stuck on the same questions. The Stoics, a school of thinkers who spent centuries arguing about fate and freedom, left behind an image that I have come to love more than almost any other. The Roman statesman Cicero records it in a book called *On Ends*.

Imagine an archer, they said. A good archer does everything in her power to hit the target. She trains for years. She chooses her bow and her arrows with care. She studies the distance, sets

her feet, steadies her breathing, draws, aims and releases. All of that belongs to her.

But once the arrow leaves the string, it does not belong to her anymore. A gust of wind can push it aside. The target can move. The bowstring may have been frayed in a place she could not see. Hitting the target is something she wants, something she has every right to want, and something she has worked for with her whole body. Yet the Stoics said that hitting the mark is "to be chosen, not to be desired." She aims for it with everything she has. She does not stake her worth on it.

When I first met this image, I felt something in my chest unclench. Because it answers the question that had tormented me, or at least it begins to.

The archer does not stop drawing the bow because of the wind. And the wind does not stop blowing because the archer trained hard. Both are real. Both shape where the arrow lands. Neither cancels the other.

So this book is organized around the archer and the forces that act on the arrow.

The bow is your effort. It is the training, the preparation, the work you do with your own hands. It is the one part of the story that is yours to shape.

The wind is luck: everything that pushes on your life that you did not choose and cannot control. Your birthplace, your parents, the economy, the mood of the person reading your application, the stranger who happens to sit next to you on a train.

The written page is destiny. Maybe you believe the arrow's path was always known, inscribed somewhere before you drew the bow. Maybe you believe destiny is only the story we tell afterward, when we look back and see a path that seemed inevitable.

Either way, the page is the place where the arrow lands, and the meaning we give it.

The breath is hope, and for many of us, prayer. Every archer knows the moment just before release, when you breathe in, hold still and send something silent toward the target. It does not move the arrow by force. But no archer who has ever lived has skipped it.

And then there is *the archer*: you. The one who has to hold all four of these at once and still decide, every morning, whether to pick up the bow again.

* * *

I should tell you plainly what this book will not do.

It will not promise you that hard work always wins. It does not, and you already know it does not, and any book that says otherwise is selling you something. It will not tell you that every loss is secretly a gift, or that everything happens for a reason you will understand one day. Some losses stay losses. You can build a good life after them without pretending to be grateful for them.

It will not settle the great theological questions about destiny. I am not a scholar of any religion, and this is not a book of theology. People of many faiths, and of no faith, will read these pages, and I want each of them to find room here. Where I mention the wisdom of a particular tradition, it is because the story is too good and too true to leave out, not because I am trying to persuade you of a creed.

What this book will try to do is this. It will give you a way to think about effort, luck, destiny and hope so that they stop fighting inside you. It will show you what the research actually says about why luck seems to love the hardworking, why the wrong

people sometimes win, and why some kinds of hope keep people alive while other kinds break their hearts. It will give you words for disappointment, which is one of the loneliest experiences there is, partly because we have so few good words for it. And it will help you decide what to do next, when you have tried hard, hoped deeply and still lost: whether to draw again at the same target, or to turn and aim somewhere new.

You will meet some people along the way. A few of them are composites: invented names and lives that I have built from the many stories I have watched unfold, so that no real person's private pain is put on display. When someone is a composite, I will tell you. Everyone else, the scientists, the soldiers, the philosophers, the prisoners, the poets, the farmer with the runaway horse, either really lived or comes from a story that people have been telling for centuries. You will find my sources in the Notes at the back of the book.

At the end of each chapter there is a short section called *For your quiver*. An archer's quiver holds the arrows she will need later. Mine holds a few lines worth remembering and one small practice to try. Take what is useful. Leave the rest.

* * *

I wrote this book for a particular person. Perhaps it is you.

You have worked hard for something. You have wanted it in a way that kept you awake. Perhaps you prayed for it. Perhaps you still do. And something went the other way: the job, the exam, the visa, the marriage, the business, the recovery, the child, the second chance. Now you are standing in the field with an empty bow, looking at the place where your arrow should have landed, and wondering whether you were a fool to aim at all.

You were not.

But I do not want to just tell you that. I want to show you why, carefully and honestly, with evidence and with stories, until you can see it for yourself.

Let's begin with a promise that most of us believed long before we knew we believed it.

Part One: The bow

On hard work: what it can do, what it cannot, and the promise we thought it made

No farmer has ever believed that plowing guarantees rain. Every farmer plows.

Chapter 1: The contract nobody signed

Let me introduce you to Sana. She is a composite, built from many people I have known and many more I have heard about, but you will recognize her.

Sana is twenty-seven. For two years she has wanted one job. It is an analyst position at the company in her city that everyone talks about, the one with the glass building and the good salary and the reputation that opens other doors. She does not want it casually. She wants it the way people want things at night.

So she prepares. She reads the company's annual reports until she can quote them. She takes an online course in the software they use. She finds two former employees and asks them, nervously, over coffee she pays for, what the interviewers like to hear. She practices her answers in front of the bathroom mirror until her younger brother bangs on the door. On the morning of the final interview, her mother prays for her, and Sana prays too, more seriously than she has prayed in a long time.

The interview goes well. She knows it goes well. She answers the hard question about the failed project with honesty and a little humor, and the senior manager smiles. On the bus home she lets herself imagine, just for a few minutes, the first day: the

badge on the lanyard, the call to her father, the life that would start from there.

Nine days later, the email arrives. It is short. *After careful consideration, we have decided to move forward with another candidate. We were impressed by your preparation and wish you every success.*

She reads it standing in the kitchen. Then she reads it again, as though the words might rearrange themselves.

The email gives her a decision. Within the hour, her mind has written a verdict.

You were never good enough. You fooled yourself. All that work was for nothing. Maybe there was no point in hoping. Maybe there was no point in praying. Maybe effort doesn't matter at all.

A single result has started to claim far more authority than it has earned.

* * *

Now let me introduce you to the other candidate. His name is Daniel, and he is a composite too.

Daniel also prepared for months. He also read the reports, practiced the answers, lay awake the night before. Daniel's grandmother also prayed. On the morning of his interview, Daniel was just as frightened as Sana.

Perhaps Daniel was a slightly better fit. Perhaps he had used the company's particular software in a previous role. Perhaps his last answer happened to touch on a project the manager was worried about that week. Perhaps the manager went to the same university and felt, without quite knowing it, a small warmth of recognition. Perhaps it was simply that Daniel's interview was at

ten in the morning and Sana's was at four in the afternoon, when everyone in the room was tired.

Sana will never know. That is one of the cruelest features of disappointment: it so rarely comes with reasons attached.

Here is what we do know. There was one job. Two people prepared seriously for it. Only one could receive it. And the result, whatever it was based on, could tell the world who got the job. It could not tell the world which of them was worth more as a human being. It could not even tell the world, with certainty, which of them was the better candidate. It could only tell us what happened.

A result tells you what happened. It does not tell you what you are worth.

* * *

Why does a moment like Sana's hurt so much? Not just disappoint, but wound, as if something has been broken?

I think it is because most of us carry a contract we have never read.

It goes something like this. *If I work hard enough, and want it sincerely enough, and do things the right way, then I will get what I am working for.* Some of us add a clause: *and if I pray, and if I am a good person, then the universe, or God, will make sure of it.*

Nobody hands us this contract to sign. We absorb it. We absorb it in school, where effort is rewarded with marks and stars and the teacher's approval. We absorb it from our parents, who tell us to work hard because they love us and because, in their own lives, it was the best advice they had. We absorb it from every story where the underdog trains, struggles and wins in the final scene. We absorb it from religious teachings, too, though of-

ten in a simplified form that the teachings themselves never quite promised.

And it is not a bad contract to teach children. It is mostly true, in the way that many useful things are mostly true. Children who work harder usually do learn more. People who prepare usually do perform better. Effort usually does improve the odds.

The problem is the word *will*. The contract says that if you do your part, the result *will* follow. Life has never agreed to that clause. Life speaks the language of odds, not guarantees. And when we meet the gap between the two for the first time, as an adult, with something enormous at stake, we do not experience it as a lesson about probability. We experience it as betrayal.

Sana is not only sad that she did not get the job. She feels cheated. She kept her side of the bargain. Where is the other side?

* * *

In the 1960s, a psychologist named Melvin Lerner began to notice something unsettling about the way people respond to suffering. He saw that people often blame victims for misfortunes they clearly did not cause: that we look at someone who has been hurt by pure bad luck and decide, without quite admitting it, that they must have done something to deserve it.

To test this, Lerner and his colleague Carolyn Simmons ran an experiment, published in 1966. Women watched what they believed was a fellow student receiving painful electric shocks as part of a learning task. (She was an actor; there were no real shocks.) The observers could not stop it. And when they could do nothing to help her, many of them did something strange. They began to think less of her. They rated her as less attractive and

less admirable than observers who had been able to change her situation, or who learned she would be compensated.

Lerner's explanation became famous as the *just-world hypothesis*. Most of us, he argued, need to believe that the world is basically fair, that people get what they deserve and deserve what they get. This belief is so precious to us that when we see undeserved suffering, we would rather rewrite the victim than give up the belief. If she is suffering, she must somehow have earned it. Otherwise the world is a place where suffering can fall on anyone, including us, at any time, for no reason at all. And that thought is almost unbearable.

The research on this has been debated and refined for decades, as good research always is. But the core insight has stayed with me, because I think it explains what happens inside a person like Sana.

When the result goes against us, the just-world belief does not disappear. It turns around and points at us.

If the world is fair, and I lost, then I must have deserved to lose. If I had really been good enough, I would have won. If I had prayed with more sincerity, it would have been answered. If I had wanted it more, worked harder, been better, it would be mine. So the failure is mine, entirely, and it says something about me, entirely.

That is the voice that wrote Sana's verdict in her kitchen. It is not the voice of truth. It is the voice of the contract, refusing to admit it was never real.

* * *

There is a second way people respond when the contract breaks, and it is the opposite of the first.

Instead of blaming themselves, they blame the whole idea of effort. *I did everything right and it didn't matter. So nothing matters. Hard work is a lie they tell you to keep you running. Luck is everything. Or destiny is everything. Either way, I am done trying.*

This is the chorus of that song: all the trying, all the distance, and in the end it did not even matter. It feels like hard-won wisdom. It feels like you have finally seen through the trick.

But notice that it is the same contract in disguise. Both responses assume that effort is supposed to guarantee the outcome. The first says: the guarantee is real, so I must have failed. The second says: the guarantee is fake, so effort is worthless. Neither one considers the third possibility, which happens to be the true one.

Effort was never a guarantee. It was a contribution.

Effort changes the odds. It does not sign a contract with the outcome.

* * *

The people who understand this best have always been farmers.

No farmer has ever believed that plowing guarantees rain. A farmer knows the whole list of things that can ruin a season: drought, flood, locusts, hail, disease, a bad market at harvest time. Every one of them is outside the farmer's control. Some years the farmer does everything right and the crop fails anyway. Farmers in every culture have stories, songs and prayers about exactly this.

And every farmer plows.

They do not plow because plowing guarantees a harvest. They plow because not plowing guarantees there will not be one. Effort does not decide the outcome. It decides whether an outcome is

possible at all. The rain may or may not come; but if it comes, it will fall on a prepared field or an empty one, and that part belongs to the farmer.

This is what the contract got wrong. It treated effort as a price we pay for a result, like money handed over at a shop counter. But effort is more like planting. You put something real into the ground. You give it every chance you can. And then you wait under the same sky as everyone else.

* * *

I want to be careful here, because there is a cheap version of this idea that does more harm than good.

The cheap version says: *Don't be sad. You can't control the outcome, so let it go.* That is not what I am saying. Sana is allowed to be sad. She is allowed to be angry. She wanted something good, she worked hard for it and she did not get it. Grief is the correct response to that. It would be strange if she felt nothing.

What I am saying is narrower, and I think more useful. Sana's sadness is appropriate. Sana's verdict is not.

She is right to grieve the job. She is wrong to conclude that her preparation was worthless, that she is not good enough, that hope was foolish or that effort does not matter. Those conclusions go far beyond what the evidence can support. One email from one company about one position cannot carry that much weight. It was never built to.

There is a difference between what we deserve and what we receive, and it helps to keep the two words apart. *Deserve* is a moral word. It belongs to the world of fairness and character and

effort. *Receive* is a word about events. It belongs to the world of odds, competition, timing and other people's decisions.

Sana deserved respect for how she prepared. She deserved to be taken seriously, and she was. She did not receive the job. Both of these things are true at the same time, and the second does not cancel the first.

Hard work deserves respect, even when it does not receive applause.

* * *

So what did Sana's effort actually do, if it did not get her the job?

I do not want to rush into consolation here, because consolation offered too quickly sounds like dismissal. But it is worth looking honestly at the ledger.

Her effort got her into the final round, out of what was probably a very large pile of applications. That is not nothing. It moved the odds from tiny to real. Her effort taught her the software, which she now knows and will carry to the next application. It taught her how to talk about her own failures with honesty, which is a rare skill. It introduced her to two people who work in the industry she wants to enter, who now know her name. And it showed her something about herself that she did not know before: that when she wants something, she is capable of going after it with discipline and courage.

None of this is the job. I am not pretending it is. If you had offered Sana all of these things in exchange for the job, she would have said no in a heartbeat.

But none of it is nothing, either. And all of it is still hers. The company kept the position. It did not get to keep what she built while trying to earn it.

* * *

Here is where I want to leave the contract.

You were taught a deal in which effort buys outcomes. It was taught to you by people who loved you, and it was mostly true, and it got you a long way. But it was never the whole truth, and there is no shame in discovering that as an adult. Everyone who aims at anything that matters discovers it sooner or later.

The truth is less tidy and, I think, more honest. Your effort is real. It matters. It is the one part of the story that is entirely yours. And it is also one force among many. The wind is real too. So are other people's choices. So, if you believe in it, is whatever is written.

The rest of this book is about how to live inside that truth without becoming either the person who blames herself for every loss or the person who stops trying altogether. There is a third way to stand. The archer knows it.

She draws with everything she has. She lets go. And whatever happens to the arrow, she does not hand her worth to the wind.

For your quiver

Effort changes the odds. It does not sign a contract with the outcome.

A result tells you what happened. It does not tell you what you are worth.

No farmer has ever believed that plowing guarantees rain. Every farmer plows.

Practice. Write down three things you once expected life, work or love to give you if you did your part. Next to each, write which kind of promise it really was: a real commitment someone made to you, a reasonable expectation, or a deep and honest wish. Notice how many of your heaviest disappointments came from the third kind being treated as the first.

Chapter 2: Sweat is not a strategy

There is an old story about two woodcutters. You may have heard a version of it; it turns up in many countries and many languages, which is usually a sign that a story is true in the way that matters.

The two men agree to a contest: whoever cuts more wood by sunset wins. The first woodcutter is famous for his strength. He starts at dawn and does not stop. Every time he looks across the clearing, he sees the second man sitting down, and every time he sees it, he swings harder. By midday his shoulders are burning. By afternoon his hands are bleeding. He keeps going, because that is what champions do.

At sunset they count. The second man has cut nearly twice as much.

"I don't understand," says the first woodcutter. "Every hour I looked over, and every hour you were resting."

"I wasn't resting," says the second. "I was sharpening my axe."

There is a line often credited to Abraham Lincoln, though nobody has ever found evidence that he said it: *Give me six hours to chop down a tree and I will spend the first four sharpening the axe.* It is probably the woodcutters' story, wearing a famous

name. That happens to good ideas; they borrow celebrities to travel further.

I start here because before we can talk honestly about luck or destiny, we have to be honest about effort. And the most important honest thing to say about effort is this: *hard work* is two different things wearing one coat.

* * *

The first thing is time and strain. Hours at the desk. Early mornings. Being tired. Sacrifice. When people say "I worked so hard," this is usually what they mean, and they are telling the truth.

The second thing is effort that is aimed: practice that targets the specific skill that decides the outcome, and that changes in response to feedback. This kind of work is often less visible and less dramatic. It sometimes involves stopping to think, which can look from the outside like resting. It is the sharpening of the axe.

The two often travel together. But they are not the same, and when they come apart, a person can pour years of the first into a goal and get very little of the second.

The psychologist Anders Ericsson spent his career studying how people become excellent. In a famous study published in 1993, he and his colleagues looked at violin students at a music academy in Berlin. The best students had not simply played more. They had spent more time in what Ericsson called *deliberate practice*: working alone, on the hardest parts, at the edge of their ability, with a clear goal and immediate feedback. Playing a piece you already know, from beginning to end, feels like practice. Playing the same four difficult bars forty times, slowly, until you stop making the mistake, *is* practice.

Ericsson's work was later squeezed into a popular slogan, the "ten thousand hour rule," which promised that anyone could master anything with enough hours. Ericsson himself spent years objecting to that simplification. The hours were never the point. The kind of hours was the point.

* * *

It is also worth knowing how far practice goes, because here, too, the honest answer is more interesting than the slogan.

In 2014, the psychologists Brooke Macnamara, David Hambrick and Frederick Oswald pulled together the results of 88 studies that measured how much people practiced and how well they performed. They wanted to know how much of the difference between performers could be explained by the difference in practice.

The answer depended enormously on the field. In games like chess, practice accounted for about 26 percent of the differences between people. In music, about 21 percent. In sports, about 18 percent. In education, about 4 percent. In professions, less than 1 percent.

These numbers are easy to misread, so let me be careful with them. They do not mean that practice is responsible for 18 percent of an athlete's success. They are statistical measures of how much of the *spread* between people tracks the spread in their practice, across the people in those studies. And the rest of the spread is not simply "luck." It includes things like the age a person started, how quickly they learn, what their bodies or minds were already suited for, the quality of their coaching and a hundred things that were not measured.

But the broad message is hard to miss. Practice matters, sometimes a great deal. And practice is not the whole story. In fields with clear rules and fast feedback, like chess or tennis, practice explains more. In the messy, shifting worlds of school and work, where feedback is slow and the rules keep changing, it explains much less.

I find this strangely comforting. It means that if you have worked hard and not yet reached the top of your field, there are many possible explanations, and "you are lazy" is only one of them, and often not the most likely one.

It also means that in most of real life, the *quantity* of effort is a weaker lever than we think, and the *direction* of effort is a stronger one.

* * *

Let me give you an example that I think about often.

Imagine two students preparing for the same exam. The first student reads her notes four times, slowly, with a highlighter. By the fourth reading the material looks completely familiar, and she feels ready. The second student reads her notes once and then spends the rest of her time closing the book and testing herself: writing down everything she can remember, checking what she missed, trying again.

The second student's study session feels worse. It is frustrating to discover how much you have forgotten. The first student's session feels better. Familiarity feels like knowledge.

In 2006, the psychologists Henry Roediger and Jeffrey Karpicke ran a version of this experiment. Students who repeatedly reread a passage felt more confident, and on a test given a few minutes later they did fine. But a week later, the students

who had tested themselves remembered considerably more. The rereaders had worked just as hard. Their effort was simply pointed at the feeling of knowing, not at knowing.

I want you to notice how easy it would be for the first student, if she failed the exam, to say, "I studied so hard and it did not matter." She would be telling the truth about her effort. She would be wrong about what it meant.

Persistence needs feedback as much as it needs courage.

* * *

There is a particular trap here that catches the most sincere people. The harder you are willing to work, the more likely you are to fall into it.

When something is not working, the natural response of a hardworking person is to do *more* of it. More applications. More hours. More pressure. More sacrifice. This feels like the honorable choice. Doing less, or stopping to question the approach, feels like giving up.

But if the method is flawed, more of it only produces more of the same result, faster. Sending the same unchanged CV to two hundred companies is not twice as diligent as sending it to one hundred. It may simply be the same mistake, made at scale. Going to the gym every day and doing the same routine that has not changed your strength in a year is real effort, and it is also real stagnation.

The woodcutter with the bleeding hands was not lazy. He was the hardest worker in the clearing. His problem was that every swing of a dull axe felt to him like proof of his commitment. He could not see that the commitment itself had become the obstacle.

A method deserves your loyalty only while it deserves your confidence.

Some people need to hear the opposite message, and I do not want to pretend otherwise. Some people really are drifting, avoiding, waiting for motivation that never comes. For them, the next step is simply to begin and to keep going on the days they do not feel like it. If that is you, you know it already, and no book can do that part for you.

But I have noticed that the people who lie awake asking whether their effort means anything are rarely the drifters. They are usually the ones who are already working past the point of exhaustion. For them, *try harder* is the least useful advice in the world. What they need is permission to stop, look at the axe and ask a few uncomfortable questions.

* * *

Here are the questions I have learned to ask, when I am working hard and not getting anywhere.

What actually decides this? Not what feels important, but what the person on the other side of the table, or the exam, or the market, actually rewards. A job interview may reward clear stories about past work more than knowledge of the company's history. A business may live or die on one customer problem that the owner keeps avoiding because the product is more fun to build. Find the deciding skill and aim there.

Where is my feedback? Feedback is information about the gap between what you did and what you were trying to do. It can come from a coach, a mentor, a practice test, a rejected draft with comments, a recording of yourself, a friend who will tell you the

truth. Effort without feedback is like archery in the dark. You can draw beautifully and never learn where your arrows go.

What will I do differently next time? If the honest answer is "nothing," then you are not practicing. You are repeating.

Can I keep this pace? This is the question hardworking people avoid most, because it sounds like weakness.

* * *

Let me stay with that last question for a moment, because our culture has made something strange out of tiredness.

Somewhere along the way, exhaustion became a badge. We tell each other how little we slept as though it were a credential. We admire the person who never takes a holiday, who answers emails at midnight, who has not seen his children awake in a week. Exhaustion feels like evidence that we are serious, that we deserve to win, that if the result does not come it will at least not be our fault.

But exhaustion is a cost, not a contribution. A tired mind learns more slowly, decides worse and notices less. A tired body gets sick. A tired person becomes harder to be around, which closes doors that a rested person would have walked through without noticing. Most of what makes effort effective, the noticing, the adjusting, the creative leap, the patience to sit with a hard problem, depends on having something left in the tank.

And there is a quieter cost, too. When we pour everything into one goal, the rest of our life gets starved: our friendships, our health, our families, our faith, our joy. If the goal succeeds, we sometimes look around and find we have won a prize in an empty house. If it fails, we have nothing to fall back on. The goal

was carrying the whole weight of our life, and when it breaks, everything breaks with it.

I am not telling you not to work hard. I am telling you that the bow needs tension and rest, and an archer who never unstrings it will one day find that it has lost its spring.

* * *

So where does this leave Sana?

If she were my friend, after she had grieved for a few days, I would sit with her and ask some of those questions. Not to tell her that the rejection was her fault; it may not have been, and she may never know. But because the next attempt is coming, and the next attempt is the one place where she has real power.

What decided that interview? She cannot know for certain, but she can ask. Some companies will tell you, if you ask politely and specifically. Some will not. She can ask her two contacts what they think the final round tends to reward. She can practice with someone who will interrupt her and push back, which is closer to the real thing than the bathroom mirror ever was. She can look at the parts of her preparation that felt good and ask whether they actually built anything, or whether, like the highlighted notes, they only made her feel ready.

And she can rest. Two years of single-minded wanting is a long time. She has earned a few weeks of doing something else.

None of this guarantees the next job. Nothing will. But it changes the odds, and changing the odds is what effort was for all along.

Work like an archer, not like someone beating the ground with a stick. The archer's effort is aimed.

For your quiver

Hard work is two different things wearing one coat: strain, and aim.

Persistence needs feedback as much as it needs courage.

Exhaustion is a cost, not a contribution.

Practice. Choose one goal you are working hard on. Write four short answers. What actually decides success here? Where can I get honest feedback? What will I do differently in the next attempt? What pace could I keep for a year? If one of these answers is "I don't know," that is your next task.

Chapter 3: The ground under the ladder

In January 1985, a Canadian psychologist named Roger Barnsley went to an ice hockey game in Lethbridge, Alberta, with his wife Paula. It was a junior league game, the Lethbridge Broncos, the kind of team where talented young players try to catch the eye of the professional scouts.

Paula was flipping through the printed program, which listed every player's date of birth. And she noticed something odd. An extraordinary number of the players had been born in January, February or March. Very few had been born late in the year.

Roger was curious enough to go and check. He and his colleagues gathered the birth dates of players across Canada's elite junior leagues and the National Hockey League. The pattern held. The closer a boy's birthday fell to the beginning of the year, the more likely he was to end up playing at the highest levels. The further it fell toward December, the less likely.

Nobody believes that stars or seasons make better hockey players. The explanation was much simpler, and much more troubling.

In Canadian youth hockey, children were grouped by calendar year, with a cut-off on the first of January. A boy born on January 2 and a boy born on December 30 of the same year played in the

same age group. At nine years old, that difference is enormous: almost a full year of growth, coordination and confidence. The January boy is bigger, stronger and faster, so the coaches pick him for the better team. On the better team, he gets more skilled coaching, more games and more time on the ice. By twelve, he really is better. By sixteen, he is much better. The coaches were not wrong. They picked the best players they could see.

What they could not see was that a small, accidental head start, a birthday, had been fed and watered for a decade until it grew into a real difference in skill.

The research has been repeated many times since, in other sports and in schools, and the size of the effect varies a great deal from place to place. But the lesson of that hockey program has never left me. Effort was real for every one of those players. They all trained. They all got up at five in the morning for practice. And some of them were training on ground that had been raised for them, without anyone noticing, before they ever picked up a stick.

* * *

The wind does not wait for us to pick up the bow. It starts blowing the day we are born.

We do not choose our parents, our country, our first language or the century we arrive in. We do not choose whether we were born healthy, whether there were books in the house, whether our family could afford for us to work without pay for a year to get experience. We do not choose whether the people with power in our society look at our names, our faces or our accents with warmth or with suspicion.

In the early 2000s, two economists, Marianne Bertrand and Sendhil Mullainathan, ran an experiment that has become one of the most quoted in the study of work. They responded to real job advertisements in Boston and Chicago with thousands of invented résumés. Some of the résumés were given names that sounded white, such as Emily or Greg. Others were given names that sounded African American, such as Lakisha or Jamal. Otherwise, the résumés were randomly matched in quality.

The résumés with white-sounding names received about 50 percent more calls for interviews.

Nobody in that study was lazy. No one had failed to prepare. The candidates were, by design, equally qualified. And yet half of them were starting the race several steps behind the line, for a reason that had nothing to do with their effort and nothing to do with chance either. It had to do with the choices of the people reading the paper.

I want to be careful with this study. It was conducted in particular cities in a particular country at a particular time, and it should not be used to diagnose any individual rejection; most rejected applicants will never know why they were turned down. But it shows something we should all be willing to see. Sometimes the ground under the ladder is uneven because of what people do, not just because of what happens.

* * *

There is a name for the way small advantages grow into large ones. In 1968, the sociologist Robert Merton called it the *Matthew effect*, after a line in the Gospel of Matthew: *to everyone who has, more will be given.* Merton was studying scientists. He noticed that when a famous scientist and an unknown one made similar

discoveries, the famous one tended to receive most of the credit, which made them more famous, which brought more funding and more students, which led to more discoveries, which brought more credit.

The Matthew effect is everywhere once you start looking. The child who reads a little earlier enjoys reading more, so she reads more, so she learns faster. The company that gets a few early customers gets reviews, which bring more customers. The job candidate with a famous name on his CV gets the interview that gets him the next famous name.

None of this means that the people who benefit did not work. Usually they worked very hard. The January hockey players trained as hard as anyone. The famous scientist earned her first success. The point is that their work was multiplied by something they did not create. Their effort was a seed, and they happened to plant it in good soil, in a sunny spot, in a wet year.

A fair account of achievement includes the ground the ladder stood on.

* * *

Warren Buffett, one of the richest people of the last century, has spent decades repeating a phrase that I wish more successful people would use. He calls it the *ovarian lottery*.

He has pointed out that he was born in the United States, in 1930, as a white man, at a moment when his particular gift, an unusual talent for judging the value of businesses, happened to be one of the most richly rewarded skills on the planet. He has said he worked hard, and he did. But he has also said, again and again, that had he been born in another time or place, the same mind and the same effort would have counted for far less.

There is something deeply attractive about a person who can say this. Robert Frank, an economist who has written a whole book about success and luck, argues that people who acknowledge the role of luck in their success tend to be more generous, and are often liked more, than people who insist they did it all themselves. And it makes sense. Someone who sees their luck can see other people's bad luck too. Someone who believes they made themselves usually believes that everyone else made themselves as well, including the people who are struggling.

* * *

Now I need to warn you about the opposite mistake, because once you have seen how much the ground matters, it is easy to fall in from the other side.

If birthdays shape hockey careers, and names shape job interviews, and parents shape everything, then perhaps effort really is a joke. Perhaps everything is decided before we start. Perhaps people who succeed were simply handed it, and people who struggle were simply robbed, and nothing any of us does makes much difference.

This sounds tough-minded. It is actually just the old contract again, turned upside down. It assumes that if effort is not *everything*, it must be *nothing*.

Look again at the hockey players. Being born in January raised a boy's odds of reaching the top. It did not put him there. Most January boys never played professional hockey; most of them, like most of everyone, played for a few years and then grew up and did other things. And some December boys, smaller and slower at nine, kept training, kept loving the game, kept showing

up, and made it anyway, often after being overlooked for years. They had to climb a taller ladder. Some of them climbed it.

The honest picture is this: circumstances set the starting height and the steepness of the climb. Effort still determines a great deal about how far up you go from wherever you start. Both are real. Pretending either one is zero is a way of lying to yourself.

Your starting point was luck. Your direction is not only luck.

* * *

There is one more distinction I think is important, and it is often blurred.

Some of the wind really is luck: the weather, an illness nobody could predict, a recession that arrived the year you graduated, the fact that the one person who could have helped you happened to move to another city. Nobody did this to you. It just happened.

But some of what we call "bad luck" is not luck at all. It is a barrier that was put there and kept there by people. A hiring manager who does not want a woman on the team. A rule that excludes people from a certain background. A family that will not let a daughter study. An institution that rewards connections over competence.

When we call these things luck, we do two kinds of damage. We hide the responsibility of the people who could change them. And we tell the person facing them that there is nothing to be done but endure, when sometimes there is a great deal that can be done: by organizing, by speaking up, by finding allies, by building something new, by changing the rules for the next person even if they cannot be changed in time for you.

Your effort does not only belong to your own climb. Some of it can go into fixing the ladder.

Advice about climbing means little when it ignores who can reach the ladder.

* * *

Let me go back to Sana for a moment.

One of the details she did not mention, even to herself, is that Daniel spent the previous summer in an unpaid internship at a company that worked closely with the one they both applied to. Sana could not do an unpaid internship. Her family needed her salary, and she spent that summer working at an accounting firm that had nothing glamorous about it at all.

Does that mean Daniel did not deserve the job? No. He worked hard during that internship, and he learned real things there. Does it mean Sana's loss was entirely about money? No. She will never know exactly why the decision went the way it did, and it would be another kind of story to decide that she does.

But it does mean that when Sana's inner voice writes its verdict, *you just were not good enough*, it is leaving something out. The two of them were not standing on the same ground. A fair account has to include that. Not as an excuse, and not as a grievance to carry forever, but as part of the truth.

* * *

What can a person actually do with all this?

I think it starts with an honest map. Not a map of how you wish things were, and not a map of how the motivational posters say things are, but a map of your real situation.

What do you have? Skills, people who care about you, health, time, savings, a language, a network, a place to live, a faith or a philosophy that holds you up. These are resources. Some of them you earned. Some were given. All of them count.

What is in your way? Some obstacles are within your power to change. Some can be negotiated. Some belong to the wind and can only be waited out or worked around. Some are barriers held in place by others, which may need more than one person to move.

Where can you get help? This is the part that proud, hard-working people skip most often. The myth of the self-made person makes asking for help feel like cheating. It is not. Every person who climbed anything was helped, whether or not they noticed.

When you make this map, two things happen. First, the shame lifts a little. You can see that your struggle is not simply a measure of your character. Second, and this surprises people, the map usually shows more room to act than you expected. Not unlimited room. But room.

That is where the archer stands: not on perfect ground, but on real ground, with a real bow, in a real wind. Knowing exactly where she stands is the first part of aiming well.

For your quiver

A fair account of achievement includes the ground the ladder stood on.

Your starting point was luck. Your direction is not only luck.

Not everything called bad luck is luck. Some of it has an author.

Practice. Draw four boxes on a page. In the first, write what you have: your resources, whether earned or given. In the second, write the obstacles you can change yourself. In the third, the obstacles you can only wait out or work around. In the fourth, the barriers that would need other people to move. Then circle one thing in the first box you have not been using.

Part Two: The wind

On luck: why it seems to love the hardworking, why it fools us, and how to judge a choice when chance has a vote

Work does not summon luck. It builds a place for luck to land.

Chapter 4: Why luck loves the hardworking

I told you at the beginning of this book about the pattern I noticed so often that I stopped calling it coincidence: when I worked hard, my luck seemed to work hard too.

It turns out that I am in very large company. One of the most repeated sayings in the English language is some version of *I'm a great believer in luck, and I find the harder I work, the more I have of it.* You will see it printed on office walls and posted under photographs of sunrise runs. It is usually credited to Thomas Jefferson.

Jefferson never said it. The researchers at Monticello, his former home, have looked carefully and found no evidence that he said or wrote anything like it. The quotation detectives who trace these things have found earlier versions in American publications of the 1920s, and a later, punchier version, *the harder I practice, the luckier I get*, in the mouths of professional golfers around 1960. Nobody knows who said it first. It seems to have been said by many people, independently, because so many people had felt it to be true.

I love that history, because it is a small lesson in luck all by itself. A saying about how luck rewards effort was, in the end, car-

ried into fame by a lucky accident: somebody attached it to a famous name, and the name made it travel. The anonymous people who actually worked the idea out got no credit at all.

But the history does not answer the real question. Is the pattern true? And if it is, *why*? Luck is supposed to be random. Why would something random favor people who work?

* * *

In September 1928, a Scottish scientist named Alexander Fleming came back to his laboratory in London after a summer holiday. Before leaving, he had stacked a pile of glass dishes in which he had been growing bacteria, and now he began sorting through them. On one dish, he noticed a patch of mold. That in itself was unremarkable; contaminated dishes were a daily nuisance, and many people would have thrown it straight into the cleaning tub.

But Fleming noticed something else. Around the mold, there was a clear ring where the bacteria had died.

That dish led to penicillin, and penicillin went on to save an unknowable number of lives. It is one of the most famous strokes of luck in the history of science. The mold spore that drifted onto that dish, probably from another laboratory in the same building, was pure chance. The timing of the holiday and the weather that summer, which allowed the mold and bacteria to grow in just the right way, was chance.

But here is the part of the story that is not luck. For years before that morning, Fleming had been hunting for substances that could kill bacteria. Years earlier he had discovered an antibacterial substance in human tears and mucus, which taught him exactly what such an effect might look like on a glass dish. When the accident arrived, it arrived in front of perhaps one of the few

people in London whose mind had been shaped, by years of work, to recognize what it meant.

Louis Pasteur had put this into words seventy-four years earlier, in a lecture at the University of Lille: *In the fields of observation, chance favors only the prepared mind.*

Notice what Pasteur did not say. He did not say that preparation creates chance. The mold would have landed on that dish whether or not Fleming was prepared. What preparation did was turn an accident into an opportunity. Without it, the same dish would have been washed and forgotten.

Preparation cannot create the accident. It decides whether the accident becomes an opportunity.

* * *

In the 1990s, a British psychologist named Richard Wiseman decided to study luck the way a scientist studies anything else. He placed advertisements asking for people who considered themselves exceptionally lucky or exceptionally unlucky, and over the years he interviewed and tested hundreds of them.

One of his experiments has become famous, and I think it is one of the most revealing small experiments in all of psychology.

Wiseman gave each volunteer a newspaper and asked them to count the number of photographs inside. That was the whole task. On average, the people who described themselves as unlucky took about two minutes. The people who described themselves as lucky took a few seconds.

The reason was printed on the second page. There, in type more than two inches high, taking up half the page, was a message: *Stop counting. There are 43 photographs in this newspaper.*

It was staring everyone in the face. The unlucky people, Wiseman reported, tended to miss it. The lucky people tended to see it.

Then, just for fun, he placed a second large message halfway through the newspaper: *Stop counting, tell the experimenter you have seen this and win $250.* Again, the unlucky people tended to miss it. They were too busy counting photographs.

When Wiseman looked more closely at the differences between his two groups, he found that the "unlucky" people tended to be more tense and anxious. Anxiety narrows attention. It makes us focus hard on the task in front of us, which sounds like a virtue, but it also makes us blind to anything we were not expecting. The "lucky" people tended to be more relaxed and more open. They also tended to meet more people, to talk to strangers, to vary their routines. In other words, they put themselves in front of more chances, and they were more likely to notice a chance when it appeared.

Wiseman's conclusion was that lucky people are not, for the most part, people to whom more random good things happen. They are people who are better at noticing and creating chance opportunities, and better at making something of the bad ones.

I would add one gentle note of caution. Wiseman's volunteers were people who *described* themselves as lucky or unlucky, and some of the difference between them may be about how they tell the story of their lives, not just how their lives went. But the newspaper is hard to argue with. Two groups of people looked at the same pages. Only one group saw the message.

* * *

So why does luck seem to love people who work hard? Having spent a long time with this question, I think there are four reasons, and none of them requires magic.

The first is simply *exposure*. The wind can only carry arrows that have been released. A person who sends out ten applications has ten chances for something unexpected to happen. A person who sends out one has one. A writer who finishes five stories has five lottery tickets; a writer who is still polishing the first page of the first story has none. Hard work, in its most basic form, puts more of your life into contact with chance. More contact means more good accidents, along with more bad ones.

A software developer named Jason Roberts once described this as your *luck surface area*. The more you do, and the more people you tell about what you are doing, the larger the surface on which luck can land. It is a wonderfully practical idea. Lucky breaks rarely find people who are hidden.

The second reason is *readiness*. Opportunities come to many people. Only some of them can use what arrives. The young musician who has practiced every day for three years can step in when the band's guitarist falls ill on the night of a big show. Her friend who has been meaning to practice cannot. Both of them got the same phone call. Only one of them had something to say yes with.

The third reason is *visibility*. When you work seriously at something, other people notice. They remember you. They mention you to someone else. A teacher recommends you. A former colleague forwards your name. A customer tells a friend. Much of what we call luck arrives through other people, and other people can only bring opportunities to someone they know is looking.

The fourth reason is *attention*, the newspaper effect. When you are deeply engaged in a field, your mind keeps scanning,

without being asked, for anything relevant to it. You notice the article, the overheard conversation, the strange result on a glass dish. Someone who is not engaged walks straight past the same signs, because they mean nothing to them.

Put these four together, and the pattern that started this book makes sense. Hard work does not bend the laws of chance. It widens the space in which opportunity can find you, and it makes you ready to recognize and use what arrives.

Work does not summon luck. It builds a place for luck to land.

* * *

Now, the honest part. Because if I only told you this half of the story, I would be repeating the contract from Chapter 1 in a cleverer form.

The first honest point is that our memories are not neutral. When a lucky break arrives after a season of hard work, it makes a great story, and we remember it. It confirms something we want to believe about ourselves and about the world. But we tend to forget the lucky breaks that arrived when we had done nothing to deserve them, because those make a less satisfying story. And we tend to forget, or at least to stop telling, all the seasons of hard work that produced no luck at all. When you look back and feel that your hard work always brought good luck, some of that feeling may be produced by which memories you have kept.

The second honest point is that we are very bad at judging how much control we have. In 1975, the psychologist Ellen Langer ran a simple experiment with lottery tickets in an office. Some employees were allowed to choose their own ticket. Others were simply handed one. Later, when asked how much money they would want to sell their ticket, the people who had chosen their

own asked for roughly four times as much. The odds were identical. Choosing just made the ticket feel more like theirs, and more likely to win. Langer called this the *illusion of control*. It is part of why we feel, after a lucky break, that our effort must have caused it.

The third honest point is that luck often has a human face. When we look back on our good fortune, we often tell it as a story about our own preparation meeting a lucky moment. We forget the person who mentioned our name, the teacher who stayed late, the stranger who held the door, the parent who paid for the course. These people were not luck. They were generosity. Leaving them out of the story makes it more flattering and less true.

Luck often has a human face. Remember to thank it.

And the fourth honest point is the one that brings us back to the people I mentioned at the start of this book: the ones who prepared perfectly and lost. Exposure, readiness, visibility and attention all improve your odds. None of them can decide what arrives. A prepared musician may never get that phone call. A brilliant scientist may spend a whole career at the bench and never see the clear ring around the mold. The lucky people in Wiseman's study still had bad days. Work can widen the space where opportunity finds you. It cannot choose what walks through the door.

* * *

There is a way of holding all this that I have found steadying.

Instead of thinking of luck as a reward that hard work earns, think of it as weather. You cannot control the weather. But you

can decide whether you are standing outside when it is good. You can make sure your field is plowed when the rain comes. You can learn to read the sky well enough to know when to plant. And when a storm comes that no preparation could have prevented, you can know that the storm was not a verdict on your farming.

This way of thinking keeps both parts of the truth. Your effort is real, and it really does tilt the odds; that is why you noticed the pattern in the first place. And the weather is real, and it does not owe you anything; that is why the pattern has exceptions that break people's hearts.

* * *

If you want to see this in your own life, there is a simple experiment you can run, and I recommend it.

For two weeks, keep a small notebook, or a note on your phone. Each evening, write down four things. What you did that day toward the things that matter to you. Any unexpected good thing that happened, however small. Any unexpected bad thing. And any help you received from another person.

Be honest. Write down the bad surprises as carefully as the good ones. Write down the lucky breaks that came when you had done nothing to earn them.

At the end of two weeks, read it all at once. Most people find two things. They find that more of their good luck than they expected came through other people. And they find that the days when they were active, when they were reaching out, trying things, showing their work, contained more surprises of every kind, good and bad, than the days when they stayed inside their routines.

That second finding is the whole chapter in miniature. Effort does not buy good luck. It buys more weather. And over a lifetime, a person who stands in more weather, with a plowed field and an attentive eye, tends to catch more rain.

For your quiver

Work does not summon luck. It builds a place for luck to land.

The wind can only carry arrows that have been released.

Preparation cannot create the accident. It decides whether the accident becomes an opportunity.

Luck often has a human face. Remember to thank it.

Practice. Keep a luck log for two weeks. Each evening, note what you did toward what matters, one unexpected good thing, one unexpected bad thing and any help you received. Record disappointments as carefully as surprises. At the end, read it all at once and notice where your luck came from.

Chapter 5: The drowned do not paint pictures

On the Greek island of Samothrace, more than two thousand years ago, there was a temple where sailors came to give thanks. When a storm caught a ship at sea, the frightened crew would make a vow to the gods: *save us, and we will honor you.* Those who reached land alive kept their promise. They commissioned small painted tablets showing their ship in the storm and their rescue, and they hung them on the temple walls. Over the years, the walls filled up.

The Roman writer Cicero tells a story about a visitor to this temple, a man named Diagoras, who had a reputation for doubting the gods. A friend took him to see the tablets. *You think the gods do not care about human beings,* the friend said. *Look at all these pictures. Look how many people made vows in a storm and were saved.*

Diagoras looked. *Yes,* he said. *But where are the pictures of those who made vows and drowned?*

I want to be careful with this story, because this is not a chapter about whether prayers are answered. We will come to prayer later in the book, with the respect it deserves. Many people who believe deeply in prayer can accept Diagoras's point completely,

because his point is not really about the gods. It is about counting.

The tablets on the wall could not tell anyone how often vows were followed by rescue. They could only tell you that survivors paint pictures. Everyone who made the same vow and went down with the ship was absent from the evidence. Not because they did not exist, but because the drowned do not paint pictures.

The drowned do not paint pictures. Every wall of success stories is missing its other half.

* * *

During the Second World War, a group of mathematicians at Columbia University in New York worked on problems for the American military. One of them was Abraham Wald, a Hungarian-born statistician who had fled Europe before the war.

One of the problems they worked on was how to protect bomber aircraft. The story, in the simplified form in which it is usually told, goes like this. The military looked at planes returning from missions and recorded where they had been hit by enemy fire. The damage was concentrated in certain areas, such as the wings and the body of the plane. The obvious conclusion was to add armor to those areas. Armor is heavy, so you cannot put it everywhere; you put it where the holes are.

Wald saw the problem. These were the planes that *came back*. The holes showed where a plane could be hit and still return. The places where the returning planes had few holes, such as around the engines, were not places that were rarely hit. They were places where a hit tended to bring a plane down, so those planes were not in the sample. The armor should go where the holes were not.

Historians have since pointed out that Wald's real work was more technical than the legend suggests; he wrote a series of mathematical memos about how to estimate a plane's weak points from the damage on the survivors. But the heart of the legend is true, and it has become the most famous example of what statisticians call *survivorship bias*: drawing conclusions from the cases that survived some process, while forgetting the ones that did not.

Once you understand survivorship bias, you begin to see votive tablets everywhere.

* * *

The business magazine profiles the founder who dropped out of university and became a billionaire. It does not profile the thousands who dropped out of university, started companies and went bankrupt. The interview with the actor who moved to the city with nothing and refused to give up does not include the many actors who moved to the city with nothing, refused to give up, and are still waiting tables. The successful investor explains her strategy on television. Nobody invites the hundreds of people who used the same strategy and lost.

These stories are not lies. The founder really did drop out; the actor really did persist. The problem is that the stories arrive without their missing half, and so we draw the wrong lesson. We conclude that dropping out, persisting and following that strategy *cause* success, when we have no idea how often they lead to failure.

Think of one of the most loved success stories of our time. J. K. Rowling's first Harry Potter manuscript was rejected by around a dozen publishers before a small London publisher took a chance

on it. The story is told and retold to aspiring writers as a lesson: *don't give up.*

It is a beautiful story, and I do not want to take it away from anyone. But Diagoras would ask a simple question. How many manuscripts were rejected twelve times, and then rejected twelve more times, and then fifty more? Their authors did not give up either. They kept sending the pages out, year after year. We do not hear their stories, because the drowned do not paint pictures.

Persistence may well be necessary for most kinds of success. That is very different from saying it is sufficient. The tablets on the wall can teach us the first. They cannot teach us the second.

Every success story has a sample size. Ask who was left outside it.

* * *

There is an even more unsettling question lurking here. Suppose we could see all the failures as well as all the successes. Would the best work always win?

In 2006, the sociologists Matthew Salganik, Peter Dodds and Duncan Watts ran an experiment to find out, in an artificial world they built themselves. They created a website where more than fourteen thousand people could listen to and download songs by unknown bands. There were forty-eight songs in all, and none of the participants had heard any of them before.

Some participants were placed in an "independent" world, where they saw only the names of the bands and songs and made their own choices. The rest were divided into eight separate worlds, each of which showed the participants how many times each song had already been downloaded by others in that world. The eight worlds started identically. Each one was a parallel uni-

verse in which the same songs, heard by similar people, competed for attention.

The results were striking. In the worlds where people could see what others were downloading, the popular songs became far more popular and the unpopular ones far less, compared with the independent world. Success became more unequal. And it became much less predictable. The same song could become a hit in one world and sit in the middle of the pack in another. Early downloads, which were essentially random, snowballed. A small lead at the beginning tended to grow into a large lead at the end.

Quality was not irrelevant. The songs that did best in the independent world rarely did terribly in the social worlds, and the songs that did worst rarely did brilliantly. But across a wide middle range, which song became a hit depended heavily on what happened to be downloaded first.

I want to be fair to this study. It was one experiment, in one artificial music market, more than twenty years ago. It cannot tell us the exact role of chance in any particular career. But it is a serious challenge to the comforting belief that the best work always rises to the top. In a world where people watch each other, and they always do, early luck can be amplified until it looks like destiny.

* * *

The economist Robert Frank, whom I mentioned in Chapter 3, added another piece to this puzzle with a simple computer simulation.

Imagine a competition with thousands of entrants. Each entrant has a score for skill and effort, and a much smaller score for luck. Even when luck counts for only a tiny share of the final re-

sult, Frank found, the winner in a large contest is usually *not* the most skilled entrant.

The reason is simple once you see it. When thousands of people compete, the best of them are extremely close together in skill. There is not much daylight between the top hundred. So the small amount of luck, the good day, the favorable judge, the timing, becomes the tie-breaker. It does not take much wind to decide a contest between archers who are all excellent.

This has a strange and important consequence. The bigger and more competitive the prize, the more likely it is that the winner is someone who was *both* very good and very lucky. The many people who were equally good, but less lucky, are invisible. And the winner, looking back, will quite naturally explain their success in terms of their skill and effort, because they really were skilled and they really did work hard. Everything they say will be true. It will just be missing the wind.

The winner's method deserves a question before it becomes everyone's rule.

* * *

None of this is meant to make you cynical about success, or to take anything away from people who have achieved great things. Most of them earned their place among the finalists through years of work. The point is to see clearly what their stories can and cannot teach.

When you hear a success story, it helps to ask a few quiet questions, the way Diagoras did.

How many people did the same thing and failed? Usually you will not know the number. But simply asking the question loosens the story's grip.

What advantages did this person have that are not in the story? Money, connections, health, timing, a particular place, a particular decade.

What would have happened with a slightly different roll of the dice? If the first investor had said no, if the song had been downloaded fourth instead of first, if the plane had been hit two feet to the left.

Does the person telling the story acknowledge luck? In my experience, the ones who do are often the most trustworthy guides.

These questions do not make success stories useless. They make them honest. A survivor can still teach you a great deal about how to sail. They just cannot tell you that their way of sailing guarantees reaching shore.

* * *

There is one more place where votive tablets hang, and it is the one most of us visit every day.

Sana, after her rejection, did what many of us do when we are hurting. She opened her phone and scrolled. And there, on the walls of social media, she found tablet after tablet. A school friend announcing a new job at a famous company. A cousin's engagement photos. A former colleague's promotion. An acquaintance's new house. Every one of them a picture of someone who reached land.

What Sana could not see were the drowned. The friend who had applied for forty jobs before this one. The cousin's two broken engagements. The colleague who was turned down for the same promotion twice. The acquaintance's debt. People rarely post their storms, only their rescues. So the wall gives a picture of

the world in which everyone else's arrows land on target, and only yours fall into the grass.

That picture is false. Not because the posts are false, but because the wall is missing its other half.

Social media is a wall of votive tablets. The drowned do not post.

So when you look at other people's success and feel your own failure more sharply, remember Diagoras on Samothrace. Look at the wall. Admire the rescues; many of them were hard-won. And then ask, gently, where the other pictures are. You will not find them. But knowing they exist is enough to stop the wall from lying to you about your own life.

For your quiver

The drowned do not paint pictures.

Every success story has a sample size. Ask who was left outside it.

It does not take much wind to decide a contest between archers who are all excellent.

Practice. Choose one success story that has shaped how you think, a famous person or someone you know. Write down three things that are missing from it: people who did the same thing and failed, advantages the story does not mention, and moments where a different roll of the dice would have changed the ending. Then ask what lesson is still left standing.

Chapter 6: The old man at the frontier

There is a story that Chinese parents have been telling their children for more than two thousand years. Its oldest written version is in a book called the *Huainanzi*, compiled at the court of a Han dynasty prince in the second century before the common era. I will tell it the way it was told to me, keeping close to the old version.

An old man lived near the northern frontier, where China met the lands of the nomadic horsemen. One day his horse ran away across the border. His neighbors came to console him. *What terrible luck,* they said.

The old man shrugged. *Who knows whether this might turn out to be a blessing?*

Some months later, the horse came back. And it was not alone. It had brought with it a magnificent horse from the nomads' herds. The neighbors came to congratulate him. *What wonderful luck!*

Who knows, said the old man, *whether this might turn out to be a misfortune?*

His son loved to ride, and he took the new horse out often. One day he was thrown and badly broke his leg. He would walk

with a limp for the rest of his life. The neighbors came again. *What terrible luck.*

Who knows, said the old man, *whether this might turn out to be a blessing?*

A year later, the nomads invaded in force. Every able-bodied young man in the region was called up to fight. Nine out of ten of them died in the war. The old man's son, because of his leg, was not taken. He and his father both survived.

The story ends there. It does not tell us what happened next, and that is part of its point. There is always a next.

In Chinese, the story is remembered in a short phrase that people still use when something bad happens: *the old man at the frontier lost his horse; how could anyone know it was not a blessing?* In modern retellings in English, the old man's answer is often shortened to a single word: *Maybe.*

* * *

I want to say very clearly what this story does *not* mean, because it is often misused.

It does not mean that every misfortune is secretly good fortune. The son's broken leg was not good. It hurt. It changed his life. If you had asked him, I suspect he would have chosen two good legs and taken his chances with the war. And we know nothing about the families of the nine young men out of ten who did not come back; for them, the story has no happy turn at all.

The old man never said the horse running away was good. He never said the broken leg was a gift. He said *who knows?* That is a very different statement. He was not putting a cheerful label on events. He was refusing to put a final label on them at all.

The old man did not say it was good. He said it was not finished.

This is the first great lesson about luck that the story carries, and I think it is one of the most useful things a human being can learn: we call things luck too early.

We label an event as good or bad luck in the moment it happens, when we can see only a small part of what it will lead to. Then we feel the full emotional weight of that label, as though it were final. But events keep unfolding. The meaning of almost everything that happens to us is still being written for years afterward.

* * *

The psychologist Daniel Kahneman, who won a Nobel Prize for his work on how people make judgments, told a story about a moment that changed his own thinking. It was not a parable. It happened while he was teaching flight instructors in the Israeli Air Force.

He was explaining to them a principle from the psychology of learning: that rewarding good performance works better than punishing mistakes. One of the instructors objected. In his experience, he said, it was the other way around. When he praised a cadet for an excellent maneuver, the next attempt was usually worse. When he shouted at a cadet for a terrible one, the next attempt was usually better. So, he concluded, praise makes people worse and criticism makes them better.

The instructor was describing something real. He was just wrong about the cause.

Any single performance, Kahneman realized, is a mixture of skill and luck. A cadet's skill does not change much from one

landing to the next. But luck does: a gust of wind, a moment of distraction, a lucky correction. An exceptionally good landing usually means the cadet's skill was helped, that time, by some good luck. The next landing, the luck will probably be more ordinary, so the result will probably be less impressive, whatever the instructor says. An exceptionally bad landing usually means skill was hurt by some bad luck, so the next one will probably be better, again whatever the instructor says.

Statisticians call this *regression to the mean*. Extreme results tend to be followed by less extreme ones, simply because the luck that helped make them extreme does not usually repeat. The instructor had been watching the wind and thinking he was watching the effect of his own voice.

Kahneman later summarized the role of luck in two short equations that I have never forgotten:

Success = talent + luck.

Great success = a little more talent + a lot of luck.

* * *

Regression to the mean is not just a curiosity for statisticians. It shapes, without our noticing, how we judge ourselves and other people.

You have an unusually brilliant day at work, and you start to believe that is who you really are. Then the next day is ordinary, and it feels like decline. You have a terrible exam, and you conclude you are hopeless at the subject. Then the next exam is better, and you credit the new study method, when some of the improvement was simply the bad luck of the first day not repeating.

Sports fans have a name for one version of this: the magazine cover jinx. An athlete has an extraordinary season and appears

on the cover of a famous sports magazine. The next season, they are less spectacular. Is the magazine cursed? No. To make the cover, an athlete usually needs an exceptional season, which usually includes some good luck. The next season, the luck evens out.

What this means for you is something both humbling and freeing. Your best moment was probably not the full measure of your ability, and your worst moment was probably not either. A single result, good or bad, contains wind. Judge yourself by the pattern over time, not by the most dramatic point in it.

A single result contains wind. A pattern contains you.

* * *

There is a second lesson in the frontier story, and it has to do with how much the "big" events of our lives actually change us.

In 1978, a team of psychologists led by Philip Brickman did a small and unusual study. They interviewed people who had recently won large prizes in the Illinois state lottery. They also interviewed people who had been paralyzed in serious accidents, and a comparison group of ordinary people who had experienced neither.

The study was small, and it has been debated and partly revised by later research. But its findings were startling at the time. The lottery winners, after the excitement settled, were not much happier than the ordinary people. In fact, they reported taking *less* pleasure in everyday activities: chatting with a friend, hearing a joke, eating breakfast. The winning had raised the bar for what felt good. The accident victims were, on average, less happy than the comparison group. But they were not nearly as unhappy as most people would predict. On the study's scale, their ratings

of their present happiness still sat above the midpoint, far from the despair that outsiders imagined for them.

We will come back to this idea in later chapters, because it matters enormously to anyone who has just lost something they wanted. But for now, notice what it says about luck. The events we label as life-changing good fortune often change us less, and more briefly, than we expect. The events we label as life-ruining misfortune also often change us less, and more briefly, than we fear. Human beings adapt. We are far more resilient, and far less easy to satisfy, than our labels assume.

The old man at the frontier seems to have known this. He never got too high or too low. Not because he did not care about his horse or his son, but because he knew that the story was not over and that he would still be himself at the end of it.

* * *

So what do we do with this?

I am not suggesting that you meet every event in your life with a shrug. That would be strange, and probably impossible. When something good happens, you should celebrate. When something bad happens, you are allowed to grieve. Feelings are not mistakes.

What I am suggesting is a small change in the words you use, especially the words you use to yourself.

When the bad news arrives, the mind rushes to write a final label. *This is a disaster. My life is ruined. It's over. I'm unlucky. This always happens to me.* These are verdicts, and verdicts are written as if the story has ended.

Try adding two words to the front of them: *so far.*

So far, this is very bad. That sentence is completely honest. It does not pretend you are fine. But it leaves a door open for what comes next. It is the old man's *who knows?* in a form that does not require you to be serene.

When good news arrives, the same practice protects you from the opposite mistake. *So far, this is wonderful.* Celebrate it fully. Just do not build your whole house on it, because the horse that arrived today may throw your son tomorrow.

We call it luck too early. Add two words: so far.

* * *

Sana, months after her rejection, would get a job at a smaller company, where she would be given far more responsibility, far earlier, than she would ever have been given at the famous one. We will come back to her story. I mention it here not to tie a bow on her loss, because she still sometimes thinks about the glass building, and some days it still stings. I mention it because on the evening she read that email in her kitchen, she was completely certain she knew what it meant.

She did not know. She could not have known. Nobody can, on the evening it happens.

That is what the old man at the frontier understood. Not that every loss becomes a gain; it does not. But that a single event, seen from inside the moment, is a page torn from the middle of a long book. You can feel what is on the page. You cannot yet read the chapter.

For your quiver

The old man did not say it was good. He said it was not finished.

A single result contains wind. A pattern contains you.

We call it luck too early.

Practice. Think of an event from five or more years ago that you labeled, at the time, as very good or very bad luck. Write down what you believed it meant on the day it happened. Then write down what it actually led to, the good and the bad. Notice how different the two accounts are. Then take one thing that is troubling you now, and write about it in a sentence that begins with "So far."

Chapter 7: A good decision can lose

On the first of February 2015, in the final seconds of the Super Bowl, the most-watched sporting event in the United States, a football coach named Pete Carroll made a decision that would follow him for the rest of his career.

His team, the Seattle Seahawks, were losing to the New England Patriots by four points. There were twenty-six seconds left on the clock. Seattle had the ball just one yard from the end zone, with three chances left to score. On the field was Marshawn Lynch, one of the most powerful running backs in the game, a man famous for carrying the ball through crowds of defenders. Almost everyone watching expected Carroll to hand the ball to Lynch.

Instead, Carroll called a pass. The quarterback threw it. A little-known Patriots player named Malcolm Butler stepped in front of the receiver and intercepted it. The game was over. New England won.

The next morning, the newspapers were nearly unanimous. It was the worst call in Super Bowl history. Carroll was a fool. He had thrown away a championship.

The poker champion Annie Duke opens her book *Thinking in Bets* with this moment, and she makes an argument that, the

first time I heard it, I resisted. Carroll's decision, she suggests, may not have been bad at all.

There was a logic to it. With little time left and only one timeout, a pass that fell incomplete would stop the clock, leaving time for two more attempts. Passes from the one-yard line were rarely intercepted. If the pass had been caught for a touchdown, people would have called Carroll clever. If it had fallen incomplete, nobody would remember it; Lynch would have got his chances on the next two plays. Only one of the likely outcomes, and an unlikely one at that, would turn the call into a disaster. And that is the one that happened.

Football experts still argue about whether the call was wise. That is fine. My point, and Duke's, is narrower. The *outcome* alone cannot settle it. A good decision can lose. And the world, almost always, judges the decision by the loss.

* * *

Poker players have a word for this mistake. They call it *resulting*: judging the quality of a decision by the quality of its result.

It is an easy mistake to see in poker, because poker makes the role of luck so obvious. A player can make exactly the right decision, betting with the best hand, and lose because the last card goes against her. Another player can make a reckless bet with a poor hand and win because the last card goes his way. Over one hand, the reckless player looks smart. Over a thousand hands, the careful player takes his money.

Professional poker players train themselves, painfully, to stop judging their play by individual hands. They review their decisions by asking whether the choice was sound given what they knew at the time, and they let the cards fall where they fall. If

they did not, they would be driven mad, or they would start learning the wrong lessons from good luck and bad luck alike.

Most of us, in the rest of life, are not trained this way. We judge our choices entirely by how they turn out.

* * *

Let me offer you a simple picture that has helped me.

Every decision we make, and every result that follows, can land in one of four boxes.

In the first box, a good decision leads to a good result. You prepare carefully for an exam and you pass. We call this *deserved success*, and it is the box the old contract promised we would always land in.

In the second box, a good decision leads to a bad result. You take the safe road home and a drunk driver hits you. You choose a stable job and the company collapses. This is *bad luck*.

In the third box, a bad decision leads to a good result. You drive home after drinking and arrive safely. You invest your savings on a tip from a stranger and it doubles. This is *dumb luck*, and it is dangerous, because it teaches the wrong lesson.

In the fourth box, a bad decision leads to a bad result. This is the box where honest learning lives, and where real responsibility belongs.

The trouble is that when we look back, we tend to collapse these four boxes into two. Good results must have come from good decisions. Bad results must have come from bad decisions. The driver who made it home safely concludes that he drives fine after a few drinks. The person who chose carefully and lost concludes that she chose badly.

Judge the decision by what you knew, not by what the dice did.

* * *

Let me tell you about Omar. He is a composite, too.

Omar was offered a job at a large company. The salary was good, a little better than his current one. But during the interviews, he noticed things that worried him. The manager he would work for spoke dismissively about the people who had left the team. Two former employees he contacted told him, separately, that the department burned through people in a year. The role was also further from the kind of work he wanted to be doing in five years.

Omar took his time. He talked to his wife and to a mentor he trusted. He looked at his savings. He thought about how likely he was to find something better within a few months, and concluded that it was reasonably likely, given the state of the market that spring. He declined the offer.

Two months later, an economic shock rippled through his industry. Hiring froze almost everywhere. The better job he had expected to find did not appear. Omar's own company began laying people off, and in the autumn, he was one of them. He spent eight months unemployed.

Throughout those eight months, people told him, some kindly and some not, that he had made a terrible mistake. He should have taken the offer. What was he thinking?

Was it a terrible mistake?

If we judge by the result, yes. Obviously. If he had taken the job, he would have had a salary during the hard months.

But if we judge by the decision, it is much less obvious. Omar had good reasons for his concerns. He gathered evidence instead of guessing. He sought advice. He considered his finances. The economic shock that followed was something that very few peo-

ple predicted. And there is no way of knowing what would have happened in the job he declined; that company also cut staff later that year, and the newest employees are often the first to go.

Omar may have made a reasonable choice that landed in the second box. He may also have made some real mistakes. Perhaps he underestimated the risk of a downturn, or did not have a backup plan. Those are worth examining. What is not worth doing is concluding, simply from the bad result, that the whole decision was foolish and that he cannot trust his own judgment.

An outcome is evidence to examine, not a verdict on the person who faced it.

* * *

I want to be careful not to swing too far the other way, because "it was just bad luck" can become a hiding place.

Some people use luck as a permanent excuse. Every failure is the market, or the boss, or the universe. Nothing is ever their responsibility. This is as much a distortion as the opposite, and it is just as dangerous, because a person who believes every bad result is bad luck will never learn anything from their mistakes.

The goal is not to protect yourself from responsibility. The goal is to place responsibility accurately. That means separating three things that tend to blur together when we look back.

What did I know at the time? Be honest. Not what you know now, but what was available to you then.

What could I have known, with reasonable effort? Sometimes the information was out there and you did not look. That is worth learning from.

What could nobody have known? The interception. The economic shock. The mold spore on the dish. These belong to the

wind.

When you separate these three, two things happen. You become much harder on yourself in a useful way, because you can see clearly where you did not do your homework. And you become much gentler on yourself in a necessary way, because you can see clearly what was never in your hands.

* * *

There is a practice that some investors, doctors and poker players use, and I think it is one of the most useful habits a thoughtful person can build. It is called a decision journal.

Before you make an important decision, write down a few things. What you are deciding. Why. What you expect to happen, and how confident you are. What alternatives you considered. What would make you change your mind. And a date, a few months or a year away, when you will look at it again.

That is all. Then you make the decision and get on with your life.

When the review date comes, read what you wrote before you knew how things turned out. This is the part that matters most, because our memories are not honest about our past reasoning. Once we know the result, we tend to remember ourselves as having been more certain, or more doubtful, or wiser, or more foolish than we really were. Psychologists have shown this many times; we will meet the research in Chapter 9. The journal is a letter from your past self that your present self cannot edit.

You will learn two kinds of things from it. Sometimes you will find that you made a careful decision and the world simply went the other way. You can let go of the shame. Sometimes you will find that you ignored a warning sign you had actually written

down. You can learn from that, specifically, without condemning your entire character.

* * *

I find the four boxes strangely consoling, and I want to tell you why.

If good decisions always led to good results, then every failure would be proof of a bad decision, and every disappointment would be a judgment on your intelligence, your character or your faith. That is the world the old contract describes, and it is a harsh world to live in, because everyone in it eventually fails.

But we do not live in that world. We live in one where good decisions can lose and bad ones can win. It sounds unfair, and in a sense it is. But it also means that your worth as a decision-maker, and as a person, cannot be read off any single result. It can only be seen in the way you choose, over and over, across many years, many decisions and many different kinds of weather.

Pete Carroll, for what it is worth, did not stop coaching after that night. He went back to work, took the criticism and kept making decisions. Some of them won. Some of them lost. That is what a career looks like from the inside, and what a life looks like, too.

A good decision can lose. A bad decision can win. Only one of them can be repeated on purpose.

For your quiver

Judge the decision by what you knew, not by what the dice did.

An outcome is evidence to examine, not a verdict on the person who faced it.

A good decision can lose. A bad decision can win. Only one of them can be repeated on purpose.

Practice. Before your next important decision, write a short note: what you are deciding, why, what you expect, what alternatives you rejected, what would change your mind, and a date to review it. Seal it, literally or digitally. When the date comes, compare your reasoning with the result, and sort what happened into what you knew, what you could have known and what nobody could have known.

Part Three: The written page

On destiny: if the story is already written, why should we write, work or pray?

If your destiny is written, your effort may be part of the ink.

Chapter 8: If it is written, why write?

Here is the question in its plainest form, the one that started this whole book.

If my destiny is already written, if I will receive exactly what I was always going to receive, then what is the point of working hard? What is the point of praying? Why should I lie awake hoping, if the ending is already on the page?

I used to think this was my question, or at least a question of my generation, worn out by competition and uncertainty. It is not. It is one of the oldest questions human beings have written down. And more than two thousand years ago, someone gave an answer to it that I still think is one of the cleverest replies in the history of thought.

* * *

The ancient Greeks had a name for the argument. They called it the *argos logos*, which means "the lazy argument" or "the idle argument." The Roman writer Cicero preserved it in a short book called *On Fate*, written in the year Julius Caesar was assassinated.

It goes like this. Suppose you are ill.

If it is fated that you will recover from this illness, then you will recover whether you call a doctor or not.

If it is fated that you will not recover, then you will not recover whether you call a doctor or not.

One of these two is fated.

Therefore, calling a doctor is pointless.

Cicero points out that if anyone took this argument seriously, they would do nothing at all in life. Why study for an exam, if passing or failing is fated? Why plant seeds, if the harvest is fated? Why look both ways before crossing the street? The argument does not just make effort pointless. It makes every action pointless.

And yet, if you believe in fate, it seems very hard to escape. Each step looks reasonable. Where exactly does it go wrong?

* * *

The answer came from a philosopher named Chrysippus, who led the Stoic school in Athens in the third century before the common era. The Stoics believed in fate as firmly as anyone ever has. They thought the whole universe was a single chain of causes, unfolding according to a rational plan. So they could not reply to the lazy argument by saying that fate does not exist. They had to find the mistake inside it.

Chrysippus found it. Some events, he said, are simple. But many events are *co-fated*: they are fated together with other events, as a package. They cannot happen without them.

It is not fated, he said, that you will recover "whether or not you call the doctor." If you are fated to recover, it may be fated that you will recover *by calling the doctor*. The recovery and the call are joined. To say "I will recover whether or not I call the doctor" is like saying "I will have children whether or not I marry," or, in an example Cicero gives, "the great wrestler Milo will wres-

tle at the Olympic Games whether or not anyone wrestles against him." It is nonsense. The outcome contains the action inside it.

Read that again slowly, because I think it changes everything.

The lazy argument imagines destiny as something that happens *to* us from outside, a result that arrives regardless of what we do, like a package delivered to an empty house. Chrysippus's reply imagines destiny as something that happens *through* us. If there is a written story, our choices are not outside it. They are among the sentences.

If your destiny is written, your effort may be part of the ink.

* * *

There is a story from the early history of Islam that makes the same point so beautifully that I cannot leave it out. I share it not as theology, but because it shows that people in very different places, with very different beliefs, have reached for the same answer to the same question.

In the year 639, the caliph Umar ibn al-Khattab was traveling with his army toward Syria. At a place called Sargh, his commanders met him with bad news. A plague had broken out in the land ahead. Umar consulted his companions, and after much discussion he decided to turn back rather than lead his people into the epidemic.

One of his most respected commanders, Abu Ubaidah, challenged him. *Are you running away from what God has decreed?*

Umar's reply has been remembered ever since. *Yes,* he said. *We are running from the decree of God to the decree of God.*

Then he gave an example. Suppose you had camels, he said, and you came to a valley with two sides, one green with grass and the other bare. If you grazed your camels on the green side,

would you not be doing so by God's decree? And if you grazed them on the bare side, would that not also be by God's decree?

In other words, the choice to act wisely is not a rebellion against destiny. It is one of the ways destiny unfolds. Turning back from the plague was not an escape from what was written. It was what was written.

Chrysippus, in Athens, and Umar, in the Syrian desert, were separated by nine centuries and two very different views of the world. Yet they arrived at the same place. For anyone who believes in destiny, effort is not the opposite of fate. It may be how fate does its work.

* * *

There is a second answer to the lazy argument, and in practice I find it even more useful, because it does not depend on what you believe about fate at all.

Suppose everything really is written. Do you know what it says?

No one has ever read their destiny in advance. Not one person. We only ever read it backward, one page at a time, after the page has been lived. Before the event, the person who believes in destiny and the person who does not are standing in exactly the same place: in front of a choice, without knowing how it will turn out.

This means that destiny, whatever it is, can never tell you what to do *next*. It cannot tell you whether to apply for the job, because you do not know whether the job is written for you. It cannot tell you whether to keep trying in a relationship, because you do not know whether the relationship is written. It cannot tell you whether to study tonight, because you do not know

whether passing the exam is written, or whether passing the exam is written *together with* studying tonight.

The only way to find out what was written is to live the page in front of you.

Nobody has ever read their destiny in advance. We only read it backward.

So the lazy argument fails twice. It fails logically, because it forgets that outcomes can be fated together with the actions that bring them about. And it fails practically, because even if it were sound, we could never use it. We cannot consult the book. We can only write in it, or be written through it, however you prefer to see it.

* * *

I want to say a word about the difference between two ideas that people often mix up, because the mixing causes a great deal of unnecessary despair.

The first idea is what philosophers call *fatalism*. In its everyday form, it says that certain outcomes will happen *no matter what you do*. The lazy argument is fatalism. So is the belief that a particular person is "destined" to be with you whatever happens, or that you are "destined" to fail whatever you try. Fatalism cuts the line between your actions and your outcomes.

The second idea is *determinism*. This is the view, held by many scientists and philosophers, that everything that happens, including human choices, is the result of prior causes. Your decision to read this book was caused by your experiences, your brain, your situation. It did not appear from nowhere.

These two ideas sound similar, but they are very different. Determinism does *not* say that outcomes happen no matter what you do. It says the opposite: that what you do is one of the causes of what happens. If you study, the studying is part of the chain of causes that leads to the exam result. That studying may itself have causes, your parents, your habits, your fear of failure. But it is still a cause. A caused action can still be a cause.

A caused action can still be a cause.

Whether determinism is true, and whether it leaves any room for what we call free will, is a question philosophers are still arguing about, and we will look at it more closely in Chapter 10. But here is what matters for now. Neither of the great ideas about a "fixed" future, religious destiny or scientific determinism, actually supports the conclusion that effort is pointless. Only fatalism does. And fatalism, as the Stoics showed long ago, does not survive careful thought.

* * *

Then why does the lazy argument feel so convincing when we are hurting?

I think it is because destiny is doing two different jobs in our lives, and we confuse them.

The first job is comfort. When something we wanted is lost, the idea that it was "not meant to be" can bring enormous peace. It tells us we did not fail because we were careless. It tells us the universe, or God, had a reason, even if we cannot see it. It lets us stop replaying the decision over and over. For many people, the words *it was not written for me* are what finally allow them to

sleep after a loss. I would never take those words away from anyone.

The second job is guidance. Here, destiny is asked to tell us what to do next: whether to try, whether to wait, whether to give up. And this is the job that destiny cannot do, because, as we have seen, we cannot read it in advance.

The trouble begins when we ask destiny to do the second job. Then it turns into waiting. *If the job is meant for me, it will come.* So we stop applying. *If he is meant for me, he will return.* So we stop living, and wait by the door. *If success is written, it will happen.* So we stop working, and are surprised when it does not.

I have watched people lose years this way. Not because they believed in destiny, but because they used destiny for the wrong job.

Destiny is a beautiful word for the past and a dangerous word for the future.

* * *

So here is how I have come to hold it, and I offer it to you whatever you believe.

When you look *backward*, at something you have already lived, you may use the language of destiny freely, if it brings you peace. *It was not meant to be. It was written. It came at the right time.* These can be honest and healing words for a page that has already been turned.

When you look *forward*, at the choice in front of you, set destiny gently aside. Not because it is false, but because it is silent. It does not tell you what to do. You must decide, with the best judgment you have, as though your choice matters, because, whether

you believe in fate or causes or neither, it does. It is part of how the story gets written.

The archer does not know where the arrow will land. Perhaps somewhere it is already known. But the archer cannot read that place before she shoots. She can only draw, aim and release. And if the arrow's landing place is written, then her drawing and aiming are written too, as part of the same sentence.

There is no version of destiny in which the bow draws itself.

For your quiver

If your destiny is written, your effort may be part of the ink.

Nobody has ever read their destiny in advance. We only read it backward.

A caused action can still be a cause.

Destiny is a beautiful word for the past and a dangerous word for the future.

Practice. Take a sentence you have said to yourself that uses destiny to stop you acting: "If it's meant to happen, it will happen," or "There's no point, it's already decided." Write it out as a full argument, step by step, like the lazy argument. Then find the step that assumes your action cannot be part of what is meant to happen. Cross it out. What is left?

Chapter 9: Reading the page backward

In June 2005, Steve Jobs stood in front of the graduating class at Stanford University and told them three stories from his life. The first was about dropping out of college.

He had left Reed College after one semester, he said, because he could not see the value of spending his working-class parents' savings on courses he did not care about. But he stayed around the campus for another year and a half, sleeping on friends' floors and sitting in on classes that interested him. One of them was a class in calligraphy. He learned about typefaces, about the spacing between letters, about what makes beautiful printing beautiful. None of it had any practical purpose in his life.

Ten years later, when he and his colleagues were designing the first Macintosh computer, it all came back. The Mac was the first personal computer with beautiful typography, he said, and if he had never dropped in on that one class, it would not have been.

Then he said the line that has been quoted ever since: *You can't connect the dots looking forward; you can only connect them looking backwards. So you have to trust that the dots will somehow connect in your future.*

It is a lovely idea, and I think it is partly true. I want to look at it carefully, because hidden inside it is the most important thing to understand about destiny as we actually experience it.

* * *

Notice what makes the calligraphy story work. It works because the Macintosh succeeded and Apple became one of the most famous companies on earth. Suppose instead that Jobs's first company had failed in its second year, as most new companies do. Would the calligraphy class still be a dot that connected? Almost certainly not. It would be a curious detail in the life of a man who dropped out of college, an interesting waste of time that nobody would ever think to mention.

The dots we connect, looking backward, are the ones that lead to wherever we happen to have ended up. They look like a path because we are standing at the end of it. If we had ended up somewhere else, a different set of dots would have lit up, and they would have looked like a path too.

This is not a criticism of Jobs. It is something every human being does. We are story-making creatures. When we look back over our lives, we cannot help seeing a shape, a direction, a sense that things led somewhere. And when the shape is strong enough, we give it a name. We call it destiny.

* * *

In the early 1970s, a young psychologist named Baruch Fischhoff ran a set of experiments that showed just how powerfully knowing the ending changes the way we see the past.

In one of them, he gave people a short account of a historical conflict they knew nothing about: a war in the early nineteenth

century between the British and the Gurkhas of Nepal. He described the background and the situation, and then asked them how likely different outcomes had been. Some participants were told nothing about how the war ended. Others were told that the British had won. Others were told that the Gurkhas had won. Others that there was a stalemate, or a peace settlement.

Whatever ending people were told, they judged that ending to have been more likely. They looked at the same evidence and found, in it, the seeds of whatever outcome they believed had happened. And they did not realize that knowing the ending had changed their judgment. They believed they would have seen it coming anyway.

In another study, Fischhoff and his colleague Ruth Beyth asked people to predict the results of President Nixon's historic trips to China and the Soviet Union in 1972, before they happened. Afterwards, they asked the same people to remember what they had predicted. People tended to remember having given higher odds to the things that actually happened, and lower odds to the things that did not. Their memories had moved toward the truth, and they had not felt them move.

Fischhoff gave this tendency a name that I find almost poetic. He called it *creeping determinism*. Once we know how something turned out, the past starts to look as though it could only have turned out that way. The feeling of inevitability creeps backward into events that, at the time, were genuinely open.

A story can make the past feel inevitable without making the future predictable.

* * *

Why does this matter for a book about destiny?

Because a great deal of what we feel as destiny is creeping determinism. It is the natural, universal feeling that comes from looking at our lives from the end of the road. It does not prove that the road was fixed. It also does not prove that it was not. It simply tells us that the human mind, looking backward, makes paths.

People who believe in destiny for deep reasons, religious or philosophical, need not be troubled by this. Their belief does not rest on a feeling of inevitability; it rests on their faith or their reasoning. But it is worth knowing that the *feeling* of "it was always going to happen" will arrive whether or not anything was ever written. It arrives for everyone, about everything, once the ending is known.

There is a word in Arabic, *maktub*, which means "it is written." It has traveled far beyond the Arabic-speaking world, partly through a famous novel about a shepherd boy following his dream, where it becomes a kind of refrain. People say it with a certain peace after something has happened: *maktub*, it was written. I love the word. But notice the tense. It is almost always said about the past.

* * *

Now here is something stranger. We do not use the language of destiny evenly.

Listen carefully to how people talk about their lives, and you will often hear a pattern. When something goes well, it is described as *meant to be*, or as the reward of effort. *I worked so hard for this. It was destiny.* When something goes badly, it is described as *bad luck*, or as someone else's fault. *I was unlucky. The timing was wrong. They were biased.*

Psychologists call one version of this the *self-serving bias*: the tendency to credit our successes to ourselves and our failures to circumstances. It is very common, and in modest doses it is probably good for us; it protects our confidence and keeps us trying.

But some people have the opposite pattern, and they are often the people who read books like this one. When something goes well, they call it luck. *I got lucky. Anyone could have done it. They must have made a mistake in choosing me.* When something goes badly, they call it their fault. *I failed. I wasn't good enough. I should have known.* Success is luck. Failure is character. This pattern is common in people who are anxious or depressed, and it is a recipe for misery, because it means that nothing good ever counts and everything bad always does.

Both patterns have the same structure. They take events that were a mixture of effort, luck and whatever else, and they sort them using different words depending on whether the outcome was good or bad. The words are doing something to us. They are turning our uncertainty into rules about who we are.

The words we use for uncertainty turn, in time, into rules for how we live.

So I suggest a small, honest discipline. When you tell the story of something that happened to you, good or bad, try to include all three: what you did, what you did not control, and what you do not know. Do this for your successes as carefully as for your failures.

I prepared hard for that interview, I was lucky that the manager had the same problem I had solved before, and I do not know how close the other candidates were. That is a true story. It is also a stable one. It will not collapse the next time things go badly.

* * *

The psychologist Dan McAdams has spent decades studying the stories people tell about their own lives. He has found that people who tell what he calls *redemption* stories, in which something bad leads, eventually, to something good, tend on average to report greater well-being and to be more engaged in caring for others and for the next generation.

This is encouraging, and I believe it. How we tell our story matters. But I want to add a caution, because there is a way of using this finding that does damage.

A redemption story cannot be forced. If you insist, in the first raw weeks after a loss, that this must be leading to something wonderful, you put pressure on yourself and on the future that neither can bear. You start scanning every day for the hidden gift, and feeling like a failure when you cannot find it. Some losses do not get redeemed in any clear way. Sometimes the dots do not connect, or not for a very long time, or not into the picture we would have chosen.

The healthy form of a redemption story is not *this was secretly good*. It is closer to *this was bad, and I did something with it*. The meaning comes from what you build after, not from pretending the loss was a present.

* * *

So what is destiny, then, in the way most of us actually live it?

I have come to think of it like this. Whatever is or is not written in the deep structure of the universe, what we experience as destiny is a reading. It is the story we tell when we look back at the pages we have lived. It is a real story, and an important one; we cannot live without it. But it is always written after the fact, in

the light of how things turned out, by a mind that naturally makes paths.

That has two consequences, and I want you to hold both.

The first is humility about the past. When you look back at a failure and feel that it was inevitable, that you were always going to lose, remember creeping determinism. At the time, it was open. You did not know. You could not have known. Your past self was standing in front of a genuinely uncertain choice, just as you are standing in front of one now. Be as fair to them as you would want to be treated.

The second is freedom about the future. The page you are on has not been read yet, not by you. Whatever you believe about who or what holds the pen, you are in exactly the position that every human being has always been in: in front of an open choice, with a story to live and no way to read the ending before you get there.

Jobs was right that you have to trust something. I would only add that you do not have to trust that the dots will connect into a beautiful picture. You can trust something smaller and sturdier: that what you do today will become one of the dots, and that you will be the one who decides, later, what it meant.

For your quiver

A story can make the past feel inevitable without making the future predictable.

Maktub, it is written, is almost always said in the past tense.

The words we use for uncertainty turn, in time, into rules for how we live.

Practice. Choose one important event in your life. Write it three times: once as a story of destiny, once as a story of luck and once as a story of effort. Then write it a fourth time, honestly including all three, plus one thing you still do not know. Read the four versions aloud. Which one would you want to believe on your worst day? Which one is true?

Chapter 10: The room you have to act

In the spring of 1870, a twenty-eight-year-old American named William James was in serious trouble.

He had trained as a doctor but did not want to practice. His health was poor. He was living in his parents' house in Cambridge, Massachusetts, unsure what to do with his life, and he had sunk into a depression so deep that, by his own later account, he thought about ending his life.

Part of what was crushing him was an idea. James had been studying science and philosophy, and he had come to find the case for determinism overwhelming. If every event was the result of earlier causes, then so was every human thought and every human choice. A person was a kind of machine, running out a program set in motion long before they were born. And if that was true, James wondered, what was the point of striving? What was the point of anything? His own will, which he desperately needed in order to climb out of his despair, seemed to him to be an illusion.

Then he read an essay by a French philosopher, Charles Renouvier, who defined free will in a way James found striking: the sustaining of a thought *because I choose to* when I might

have other thoughts. And on the thirtieth of April, 1870, James wrote in his diary:

I think that yesterday was a crisis in my life... My first act of free will shall be to believe in free will.

It was not an argument. James knew it was not an argument. He had not proved that determinism was false. He had simply decided that he would live as though his choices mattered, and see what happened.

What happened was that he slowly recovered. Not overnight, and not completely; he struggled with low moods for the rest of his life. But he never again sank as deep. He went on to become one of the founders of modern psychology and one of the most humane and readable philosophers America has produced. Much of his later work was about the practical difference that beliefs make in the way people live.

* * *

I tell you this story not because it settles the question of free will. It does not. Philosophers and scientists are still arguing about it, more fiercely than ever.

Some argue, as James feared, that free will is an illusion. The neuroscientist Robert Sapolsky, in a book called *Determined*, published in 2023, makes the case that every human action is the product of biology and circumstance: of genes, hormones, brain chemistry, childhood, culture and the events of the last few seconds, all the way down. There is no room, he says, for a self that floats free of all that and makes choices on its own.

Interestingly, Sapolsky does not conclude that we should all stop trying. He concludes that we should become far more compassionate, toward others and toward ourselves, because nobody

chose the forces that made them who they are. The person who failed did not freely choose to fail. Neither, for that matter, did the person who succeeded freely choose to succeed.

Many other philosophers disagree with him. A large group, often called *compatibilists*, argue that the kind of freedom that matters to us was never about escaping causes. It is about acting on your own reasons, in line with your own values, without being forced or tricked. A person who chooses to study medicine because she cares about healing people is acting freely in this sense, even if her caring has causes. A person who studies medicine because her father will disown her if she does not is less free, even if both choices have causes.

I am not going to settle this debate in a chapter, and I do not need to. Here is the thing I find most useful about it: almost nothing about how you should live tomorrow depends on how it is settled.

* * *

Think about what actually happens when you face a hard decision. Should you leave your job? Should you apply to study abroad? Should you have a difficult conversation with someone you love?

You deliberate. You weigh reasons. You imagine outcomes. You feel the pull of different possibilities. Whatever is going on in your brain underneath, and whatever philosophers eventually decide it means, you cannot step outside of this process. You cannot sit back and watch yourself decide like someone watching a film. Even the decision to “let fate decide” is a decision, and it has consequences like any other.

As we saw in Chapter 8, a caused action can still be a cause. Your deliberation is part of the chain that produces the result. So even if James's worst fear were true, even if every choice is the product of causes, the practical question in front of you is still the same one: what should I do?

And there is a second practical question underneath it, one that I think is much more important than the metaphysical one. It is not *am I free?* It is *how much room do I have to act?*

* * *

Room is a better word than freedom for most of real life, because room comes in different sizes.

Imagine two people who both want to leave jobs they hate and train for a new career.

The first is single, has no children, has savings that would cover a year without income and has parents who would let her move back home if things went badly. Her room to act is large. She can take a risk, because the cost of failure is survivable.

The second has two young children, a mortgage, a parent who depends on her for care and no savings to speak of. Her room to act is much smaller. She has the same wish, and perhaps the same courage. But a choice that would be bold for the first woman might be reckless for her.

If we told both of them simply to *follow your dreams* or *take responsibility for your life*, we would be speaking nonsense to one of them. They do not have the same amount of room. Pretending they do is not inspiring. It is cruel.

But notice that the second woman is not without room. Hers is smaller, and its shape is different. Perhaps she can begin a course in the evenings. Perhaps she can build savings slowly for

two years. Perhaps she can find a role that bridges the old career and the new. Perhaps she can ask for help she has been too proud to ask for. Her choices are real. They are just harder, and they will take longer.

Taking responsibility begins with an honest account of the room you have to act.

* * *

It helps, when the room feels small, to name exactly what is making it small. Constraints become much less overwhelming when they are named one by one, instead of felt all at once as a vague weight of impossibility.

Some constraints are *outside you* and *fixed*, at least for now: a law, an illness, a family duty you are not willing to abandon, the state of the economy.

Some are *outside you* but *negotiable*: an employer who might agree to flexible hours, a family that might share a responsibility, a bank that might restructure a loan, a deadline that might be moved if you ask.

Some are *inside you*: habits, fears, beliefs about what people like you are allowed to do, an old story about your own limits. These can be the hardest to see and, sometimes, the most possible to change.

And some are simply *missing information*. You do not know whether something is possible because you have never asked.

When you sort your constraints this way, the room often turns out to be larger than it felt. Not unlimited. Never unlimited. But a person who believes they have no room at all is usually looking at a mixture of real walls and painted ones, and cannot tell them apart in the dark.

A choice becomes clearer when its constraints are named.

* * *

There is a sentence by the psychiatrist Viktor Frankl that is quoted so often it has almost been worn smooth. He wrote it after surviving the Nazi concentration camps, in a book called *Man's Search for Meaning*:

Everything can be taken from a man but one thing: the last of the human freedoms—to choose one's attitude in any given set of circumstances, to choose one's own way.

I want to treat this sentence carefully, because it is often misused. Frankl was not saying that attitude is all that matters, or that people who suffer simply need a better attitude. He was a prisoner in a place designed to strip human beings of every other kind of room. His point was that even there, in the smallest room any human being has ever been forced into, he found that some room remained. Not enough to save himself; he survived partly by chance, and he knew it. But enough to remain himself.

If that was true in the camps, then it is true in your situation too. Your room may be small. It is almost never zero.

* * *

There is one more thing I want to say about room, and it is the most hopeful thing in this chapter.

Room is not fixed. You can make it larger.

Every month of savings is room. Every new skill is room. Every person who knows and trusts you is room. Every year of good health is room. Every piece of information you gather about your options is room. None of these guarantee anything. But each one gives your future self more choices, more ways to respond

when the wind changes, more doors to walk through when one closes.

This is one of the most practical answers I know to the questions that began this book. If you cannot control the outcome, and you cannot read your destiny, and you cannot be sure your choices are free in the deepest philosophical sense, what *can* you do? You can widen your room. You can make sure that, whatever happens, you will have more ways to respond to it.

The archer did not choose her height, the length of her arms, the bow she was first handed or the wind on the day of the contest. Those were given. But within them, she chose where to stand, how to train, which arrows to carry and, finally, where to aim. And over years, by her choices, she made her own room larger: a stronger draw, a steadier hand, a better eye for the wind.

William James could not prove that he was free. He decided to act as though his room was real, and then he spent his life making it larger. That, I think, is as good an answer to the question as anyone has found.

Freedom is not only something to believe in. It is a room you can make larger.

For your quiver

Taking responsibility begins with an honest account of the room you have to act.

A choice becomes clearer when its constraints are named.

Your room may be small. It is almost never zero.

Freedom is not only something to believe in. It is a room you can make larger.

Practice. Think of a choice you feel stuck on. List every constraint you can think of, then sort each one into four groups: outside me and fixed, outside me but negotiable, inside me, and missing information. Pick one item from the "negotiable" or "missing information" group and take one step on it this week: ask the question, have the conversation, look up the answer.

Part Four: The breath

On prayer and hope: what they do, what they cannot do, and the kind of hope that keeps people alive

Prayer is what effort sounds like when it reaches the edge of its power.

Chapter 11: Trust, and tie the camel

Aesop, the storyteller of ancient Greece, left us a fable about a man driving a heavy wagon along a country road after the rains.

The road was deep with mud, and before long the wheels sank in up to the axles. The horses strained and could not move it. So the driver climbed down, knelt in the road and began to pray. He called on Hercules, the strongest of all the heroes, to come and lift his wagon out.

Hercules appeared. But he did not lift the wagon. *Get up,* he said. *Put your shoulder to the wheel and drive your horses on. The gods help those who help themselves.*

More than a thousand years later, far to the south-east in Arabia, Muslims preserved the memory of a man who came to the Prophet Muhammad with a practical question about his camel. Should he tie it up and trust in God, he asked, or leave it loose and trust in God? The answer he received has become a proverb in many languages: *Tie it, and trust.*

In Spain they say *a Dios rogando y con el mazo dando*: praying to God and swinging the mallet. The story behind it is about a carter whose wagon broke down. He begged a saint to fix it, and the saint told him, in effect, *I will pray; you take up the hammer.* In the monasteries of medieval Europe, the Benedictine monks

summed up their whole way of life in three Latin words: *ora et labora*, pray and work.

What strikes me about all these sayings is where they come from. They were not invented by skeptics mocking the faithful. They were invented by deeply religious people, in deeply religious cultures, as advice to each other. Every people that learned to pray also invented a proverb telling you to keep working.

Every people that learned to pray also invented a proverb about working.

* * *

This chapter is about prayer, and I want to begin by being honest about what I can and cannot say.

I cannot tell you what happens on the other side of a prayer. Whether God hears, how God answers, whether prayer changes events in the world or only the person who prays: these are questions of faith. People of different religions answer them differently, and people of no religion answer them in yet another way. No book about luck and effort can settle them, and this one will not try.

What I can talk about is what prayer evidently does on *this* side, in the life of the person who prays. Anyone can observe this, believer or not. And I think it turns out to be one of the most important parts of the answer to the question that started this book.

But first we have to clear away a misunderstanding, because it causes enormous pain.

* * *

There is a way of praying that is really the old contract from Chapter 1, wearing religious clothes.

It goes like this. *If I pray sincerely enough, often enough, with enough tears, God will give me what I ask.* Sometimes it becomes even more explicit: *If I fast, if I give to charity, if I make this vow, then You will give me the job, the marriage, the child, the cure.*

There is nothing wrong with asking. Almost every tradition encourages people to bring their deepest wishes to God, plainly and without embarrassment. The problem is the *if-then*. It turns prayer into a transaction, and God into a kind of machine that dispenses outcomes in exchange for devotion.

When this kind of prayer is followed by a *no*, the damage is double. The person loses the thing they wanted. And they conclude that they must have prayed wrongly, or not sincerely enough, or that God has rejected them, or that God does not exist. The just-world belief from Chapter 1 has turned around again and pointed at the soul.

The great religious traditions, for the most part, have warned against exactly this. They speak of trust, surrender, patience, a wisdom larger than ours. They do not promise that every request will be granted in the form it was asked. The vending-machine version of prayer is not their teaching. It is our anxiety, borrowing their language.

* * *

Think about what happens, though, when two people pray for the same thing.

On the morning of the final interview, Sana's mother prayed for her daughter to get the job. On the same morning, in another part of the city, Daniel's grandmother prayed for her grandson to

get the same job. Both prayers were sincere. Both came from love. Both were offered by good people.

There was one job.

Whatever you believe about how prayer works, this simple fact should free us from the idea that an unanswered prayer is a verdict on the person who prayed. In a world where many people want the same scarce things, the same position, the same scholarship, the same person's heart, not every sincere prayer for a particular outcome *can* be granted in that form. Sana's mother's prayer was not weaker than Daniel's grandmother's. It was not less loved. It met a world in which only one arrow could hit that particular target.

An unanswered prayer is not a verdict on the one who prayed.

Believers have many ways of understanding a *no*. Some say it means *not yet*. Some say it means *something better*. Some say every sincere prayer is answered, though not always in the way we expect or can see. Some simply say that God's wisdom is beyond ours, and they rest in that. I will not choose among these for you. Each of them, held honestly, can bring peace. The only understanding I would warn against is the one that says: *you did not get it because you were not good enough to deserve it.* That is not faith. That is the contract.

* * *

So what does prayer do, on this side?

I have watched people pray all my life. When I listen past the differences in language and belief, I hear a handful of things again and again.

Prayer names what you want. This sounds trivial, but it is not. Many of us go through life with a fog of half-formed wishes. When you pray, you have to say what you are asking for, and in saying it, you often discover what you actually want, which is sometimes different from what you thought. A person who prays, night after night, for "the job" may find one night that the words have changed into a prayer for security, or respect, or the chance to use their gifts. That discovery matters. It opens other roads to the same place.

Prayer marks the edge of your power. Nobody prays to be able to lift their own hand. We pray about the things we cannot fully control: the decision of the interviewer, the result of the scan, the heart of another person, the safety of a child far away. In this sense, prayer is a kind of honesty. It draws the line, in the open, between the bow and the wind. It says: *I have done what I can. The rest is not in my hands.*

There is a prayer, written by the American theologian Reinhold Niebuhr in the twentieth century, that millions of people now say every day, many of them in recovery from addiction. It is usually given in a short form:

God, grant me the serenity to accept the things I cannot change, courage to change the things I can, and wisdom to know the difference.

If you read that prayer slowly, you will see that it contains this entire book in a single breath. The bow, the wind and the wisdom to tell them apart.

Prayer steadies the archer. Ask people what they feel after praying, and many will tell you, before anything else, that they feel calmer. Fear narrows the mind, as we saw with Wiseman's unlucky volunteers counting photographs. A person who has handed over what cannot be controlled can sometimes see more

clearly what can. The archer who breathes out before release does not change the wind. But she stops shaking.

Prayer sends you back to work. This is what Hercules told the waggoner, and what the Prophet told the man with the camel, and what the Spanish saint told the carter. The prayer is not the end of the action. It is the moment before the action. You kneel; then you stand up and put your shoulder to the wheel. In every tradition I know of, the people most respected for their prayer were also respected for their work.

Prayer connects you. People pray for each other and with each other. A mother prays for her daughter. A community prays for the sick. A stranger lights a candle. Even when the outcome does not change, the person on the receiving end of that prayer is no longer alone with their fear. Loneliness is one of the heaviest parts of disappointment, and prayer, at its best, lifts some of it.

Prayer is what effort sounds like when it reaches the edge of its power.

* * *

There is one more thing I must say, because it answers the specific question that troubled me for years.

If destiny is written, why pray?

You already know the answer from Chapter 8, because it is the same answer that Chrysippus gave in Athens and that Umar gave in the desert. If there is a written story, prayer is not outside it. For a believer, the prayer may be one of the sentences on the page, co-written with the outcome, just as calling the doctor is co-written with the recovery. Some traditions go further still. In the Islamic tradition, for example, there is a well-known saying, traced by many Muslims to the Prophet, that *nothing turns back*

the decree except supplication. However one understands that, it clearly does not treat prayer as pointless in the face of destiny. It treats prayer as part of how destiny moves.

And if you do not believe in a written story, then prayer, or its secular cousins, reflection, intention, hope spoken out loud, still does everything I described above on this side. It names, it marks the edge, it steadies, it sends you back to work, it connects. You do not need to settle the metaphysics to receive these gifts.

* * *

I want to speak for a moment to readers who do not pray, or who used to and have stopped.

Perhaps you stopped because a prayer went unanswered when it mattered most. If so, I am sorry. That is one of the deepest kinds of loss, because it is the loss of a future and of a source of comfort at the same time. I am not going to tell you to start praying again. That is between you and your own conscience.

But I would gently suggest that the needs prayer meets do not disappear when the prayer stops. You still need a way to name what you want, to mark the edge of your power, to steady yourself before you act and to feel less alone in the waiting. Some people find this in meditation, some in journaling, some in long walks, some in honest conversation with a friend, some in music. Whatever form it takes, find something to put in that place. An archer who never breathes before she releases does not shoot better. She just shoots afraid.

* * *

Let me end with the camel, because I love that story more each time I think about it.

Notice what the man was really asking. He wanted to know whether trust and effort were rivals, whether choosing one meant giving up the other. And notice the answer. It did not say *tie the camel instead of trusting*. It did not say *trust instead of tying the camel*. It said both, in order: tie it, and trust. Do everything that is yours to do. Then place the rest, with an open hand, where it belongs.

That is what the archer does in the moment before release. She has trained, she has aimed, she has done everything her hands can do. Then she breathes, and whether she sends that breath upward to God or simply out into the air, she lets the arrow go.

Prayer does not draw the bow for her. It never did. But no archer I have ever heard of has refused to breathe.

For your quiver

Every people that learned to pray also invented a proverb about working.

An unanswered prayer is not a verdict on the one who prayed.

Prayer is what effort sounds like when it reaches the edge of its power.

Tie the camel. Then trust.

Practice. If you pray, the next time you pray about something you want, divide your prayer into two halves. In the first half, ask honestly for what you want. In the second, name one specific thing that is yours to do about it, and ask for the strength to do it. Then, as soon as you can, do that thing. If you do not pray, try the same exercise in writing: one paragraph of honest hope, one sentence of honest action.

Chapter 12: The thing with feathers

The oldest story about hope that I know is also one of the strangest.

The Greek poet Hesiod, writing around seven hundred years before the common era, tells how the god Zeus, angry with humankind, created the first woman, Pandora, and sent her to earth with a large storage jar. (Centuries later, a translator turned the jar into a "box," and the box is how most of us know the story.) Inside the jar were all the evils that would trouble human life: sickness, toil, sorrow and the rest. Before then, people had lived without them.

Pandora lifted the lid. The evils flew out and scattered across the world, where they have been ever since. In terror, she slammed the lid back down. And one thing was left inside, caught under the rim of the jar, unable to escape.

It was hope.

For nearly three thousand years, people have argued about what this means. Why was hope in a jar full of evils? Was it trapped inside so that it would stay with us, the one consolation we kept? Or was it kept from us? Or was hope itself one of the evils, the cruelest of them all?

The German philosopher Friedrich Nietzsche chose the darkest reading. Zeus, he wrote, did not want human beings to throw their lives away, however much the other evils tormented them. He wanted them to go on letting themselves be tormented. So he gave them hope, which is in truth the worst of all evils, because it drags out human suffering.

When I first read that, I wanted to argue with it. Then I thought of the people I know who spent years waiting for something that was never going to come, and I was less sure.

* * *

Some seventeen years before Nietzsche wrote those words, in a small town in Massachusetts, a woman who rarely left her family's house wrote a poem that gives the opposite answer. Emily Dickinson published almost nothing in her lifetime, and her poems were only gathered and printed after her death. This is one of them:

"Hope" is the thing with feathers —
That perches in the soul —
And sings the tune without the words —
And never stops — at all —

The poem goes on to say that this small bird keeps singing through the worst storms, in the coldest land and on the strangest sea. And then it ends with two lines that I find almost unbearably moving:

Yet — never — in Extremity,
It asked a crumb — of Me.

For Dickinson, hope is not a torment. It is a gift that asks for nothing. It keeps singing whether or not the singing changes anything. It is what keeps a person company in the dark.

So who is right, Nietzsche or Dickinson? Is hope the last evil in the jar, or the bird that sings in the storm?

I have come to believe they are both right, because they are describing two different things that share a name.

* * *

In the 1980s and 1990s, a psychologist at the University of Kansas named Charles Richard Snyder set out to study hope scientifically. Until then, most psychologists had treated hope as a vague, warm feeling, something like optimism. Snyder argued that real hope is something more specific, and more practical.

Hope, in his account, has two parts.

The first he called *agency*. It is the sense that you can get yourself moving toward a goal and keep going. Snyder sometimes called it *willpower*. It is the inner voice that says, *I can do this. I will keep at it.*

The second he called *pathways*. It is the ability to see routes to your goal, and, most important, to find new routes when the first one is blocked. Snyder sometimes called it *waypower*. It is the inner voice that says, *Here is how. And if that doesn't work, here is another way.*

Snyder and his colleagues developed a short questionnaire to measure these two parts, and over the following decades, researchers used it in hundreds of studies. People who scored higher on hope tended to set clearer goals, to come up with more ways to reach them and to keep going longer when they met obstacles. Higher hope has been linked, in many of these studies, with better results in school and sport and with better coping in illness.

What I find most useful about Snyder's idea is the second part. High-hope people are not simply people who feel sure things will work out. They are people who can see more than one road. When one closes, they do not conclude that the destination is lost. They start looking for another way.

Give your hope more than one road to travel.

* * *

The psychologist Gabriele Oettingen, working in Germany and later in New York, discovered something about hope that surprised even her, and that I think every person who dreams about something should know.

In one of her studies, published with Doris Mayer in 2002, she asked university students who were about to graduate how often they fantasized about getting their dream job, and how positive those fantasies were. Then she followed them for two years.

You might expect that the students with the most vivid and positive fantasies would do best. They were the most hopeful, weren't they? The opposite happened. The graduates who had indulged most in positive fantasies about their future had, two years later, received fewer job offers and were earning lower salaries than those whose thoughts about the future had been more mixed. Oettingen found similar patterns elsewhere: in people hoping to recover well from surgery, in students with a crush hoping to start a relationship.

Her explanation is that a vivid positive fantasy lets the mind taste the reward in advance. It feels wonderful. And because it feels as though we have already arrived, it drains away some of the energy we need to actually make the trip. Fantasy is a rehearsal of the destination. It is not a rehearsal of the road.

But Oettingen did not conclude that we should stop dreaming. She found that the dream becomes powerful when it is joined to a clear look at the obstacle. She called this *mental contrasting*: first imagine the wish and the best outcome, and then imagine, just as vividly, the main thing inside you or around you that stands in the way. When people did this, those who had a reasonable chance of success became more energized and more likely to act. She later combined it with a simple if-then plan, *if this obstacle appears, then I will do that*, into a method she calls WOOP: Wish, Outcome, Obstacle, Plan.

I should be honest about the size of the effect. A review of the research published in 2021 found that combining mental contrasting with if-then plans helps people reach their goals on average, but the effect is small to moderate, and some of the published studies may have overstated it. It is a useful tool, not a magic one. But the underlying insight seems sound to me, and it matches what I have seen in life. The people who dream best are not the people who dream most. They are the people who let their dream look straight at the obstacle.

Fantasy rehearses the arrival. Hope rehearses the road.

* * *

Now we can see what Nietzsche and Dickinson were each describing.

Nietzsche's hope is the hope that becomes a substitute for action and a refusal to look at reality. It is the fantasy that keeps a person waiting at a door that has closed, rehearsing a reunion that will not happen, putting off every other possibility because *this* one must surely come true. That kind of hope really can pro-

long suffering. It is a bird that sings so sweetly that you never leave the cage.

Dickinson's hope is something else. It does not demand a particular outcome. It does not ask a crumb. It is closer to a basic orientation of the soul toward life, a refusal to let the darkness have the last word, even when you do not know what morning will bring.

And Snyder's hope, the hope of agency and pathways, is the practical bridge between them. It keeps the bird singing, but it also gets you walking.

* * *

There is one more voice I want to bring into this conversation, because I think it reaches the deepest place.

Václav Havel was a Czech playwright who, for years, opposed the communist government of his country. He was harassed, watched and imprisoned. His plays were banned. During those years, he had every reason to believe that nothing he did would ever change anything; the regime looked permanent. In a series of conversations recorded in the mid-1980s and later published as *Disturbing the Peace*, he was asked whether he had hope.

His answer is one of the most quoted things ever said on the subject:

Hope is not the conviction that something will turn out well, but the certainty that something makes sense, regardless of how it turns out.

A few years after he said this, in 1989, the regime fell, almost without bloodshed, and Havel became the president of his country. But notice that his hope did not depend on that. He was not hoping because he predicted the fall of the government. He was

hoping because he believed that living truthfully *made sense*, whether the government fell or not.

This is hope that cannot be broken by the outcome, because it was never staked on the outcome. It is staked on meaning. And it is, I think, the kind of hope the archer needs most. She hopes to hit the target. Of course she does. But underneath that hope is a deeper one: that drawing the bow well is worth doing, that the practice and the aim and the courage to release make sense, whether this particular arrow lands or not.

Hope is not a prediction. It is a direction.

* * *

Let me pull these threads together, because I think we now have a working picture of healthy hope.

Healthy hope has a *direction*: something you value, something worth moving toward. That is Havel's hope, and Dickinson's bird.

Healthy hope has *roads*: concrete next steps and more than one route. That is Snyder's pathways.

Healthy hope looks at the *obstacle*: it does not pretend the road is clear. That is Oettingen's contrast.

And healthy hope does not set a single outcome as the price of its own survival. It is the bird that asks for no crumb.

Unhealthy hope tends to be the reverse: a single fixed outcome, no roads but one, no look at the obstacles, and a mind that tastes the arrival so often that it forgets to walk. That is the hope Nietzsche feared, and he was right to fear it.

* * *

When Sana was preparing for her interview, she sometimes let herself imagine her first day at the company: the lanyard, the call to her father. That was natural, and it gave her pleasure, and I would not take it from her. But the parts of her preparation that actually changed her odds were not the fantasies. They were the moments when she looked straight at the obstacle. *I freeze when they ask about failures. So I will practice that answer until I don't.* That was hope rehearsing the road.

After the rejection, when she was ready, her hope had to change shape. It could no longer be a hope for that particular glass building. But when she asked herself what that job had stood for in her imagination, she found three things underneath it: the security of a good salary, the respect of doing serious work and the chance to learn quickly from talented people. None of those lived only inside one building.

Her hope, in other words, had a direction that survived the loss of one road. That is the kind of hope that does not get trapped in the jar.

For your quiver

Fantasy rehearses the arrival. Hope rehearses the road.

Give your hope more than one road to travel.

Hope becomes practical when it can name a next step.

Hope is not a prediction. It is a direction.

Practice. Write down one thing you are hoping for. Underneath it, write the main obstacle, inside you or around you, as honestly as you can. Then write one if-then plan: "If this obstacle appears, then I will…" Finally, write one other road that could lead to what this hope is really about.

Chapter 13: The optimists who did not come home

In September 1965, an American navy pilot named James Stockdale was shot down over North Vietnam. He ejected, landed in a village, was beaten by the people who found him and was taken to a prison in Hanoi that the American prisoners would later call, with bitter humor, the Hanoi Hilton.

He stayed there for more than seven years.

As the most senior navy officer among the prisoners, Stockdale became a leader of the men held there. He was tortured many times. He spent long periods in solitary confinement, sometimes in leg irons. He had no rights as a prisoner, no date of release and no way of knowing whether he would ever see his wife and sons again. He did not know whether the war would end in one year or ten.

Stockdale was released in 1973. Decades later, the business writer Jim Collins interviewed him for a book about why some companies become great. Collins asked a simple question. Who didn't make it out?

Oh, that's easy, Stockdale said. *The optimists.*

Collins was confused. The optimists?

The optimists. Oh, they were the ones who said, "We're going to be out by Christmas." And Christmas would come, and Christmas would go. Then they'd say, "We're going to be out by Easter." And Easter would come, and Easter would go. And then Thanksgiving, and then it would be Christmas again. And they died of a broken heart.

Then Stockdale said something that Collins would later call the *Stockdale Paradox*:

You must never confuse faith that you will prevail in the end—which you can never afford to lose—with the discipline to confront the most brutal facts of your current reality, whatever they might be.

* * *

I want to be careful with this story, as I have tried to be careful with every story in this book. Stockdale was describing his memories of a terrible place, many years later. He was not running a study. We do not know, and cannot know, exactly why particular men did not survive; illness, injury, torture and despair were all bound up together. One man's observation is not a law of nature.

But Stockdale was not the only person to see this pattern.

Twenty years before Stockdale was shot down, the Austrian psychiatrist Viktor Frankl was a prisoner in the Nazi concentration camps. In *Man's Search for Meaning*, the book he wrote soon after his liberation, he describes something the chief doctor of his camp told him. In the week between Christmas 1944 and New Year 1945, the death rate in the camp rose beyond anything they had seen before. The work had not become harder. The food had not become worse. The weather had not changed in any special way. The doctor's explanation was that a great many prisoners

had lived in the naïve hope that they would be home by Christmas. As the day came closer and there was no encouraging news, they lost courage, and the disappointment overcame them.

Frankl also tells the story of a fellow prisoner who confided in him, in February 1945, that he had had a strange dream. A voice had told him that he could ask any question and it would be answered. He had asked when the war would end, for him. The voice had answered: on the thirtieth of March.

The man was full of hope. But as the thirtieth of March approached, the news from the front showed no sign of liberation. On the twenty-ninth, he suddenly became ill and ran a high fever. On the thirtieth, the day the voice had promised, he lost consciousness. On the thirty-first of March, he died.

Frankl was a doctor, and he did not pretend that disappointment alone had killed his friend. The man died of typhus, a disease that was everywhere in the camps. But Frankl believed, from long observation, that the sudden collapse of hope had weakened the body's ability to resist it.

* * *

Two men, in two different wars, in two of the worst places human beings have ever built, saw the same thing. I do not think it is a coincidence. And I think what they saw has something to teach those of us whose struggles are, thank God, much smaller.

What failed, in both stories, was not hope. It was hope with a date.

The prisoners who said *we'll be out by Christmas* were not wrong to want freedom. They were not wrong to believe it would come; for many of them, eventually, it did. Their mistake, if it can be called a mistake in a place of such suffering, was to tie their

hope to a specific outcome at a specific time. They made an appointment with the future. And the future did not keep it.

When a hope with a date is broken, it is not broken once. It is broken again and again, every time the next date passes. Each disappointment takes something that cannot easily be replaced. Eventually, there is nothing left to hope with.

Hope that sets a date with the universe will one day be stood up.

* * *

What survived?

Stockdale described two things that he held at the same time, and he insisted that they had to be held together.

The first was faith in the end of the story. *I never lost faith in the end of the story,* he told Collins. *I never doubted not only that I would get out, but also that I would prevail in the end and turn the experience into the defining event of my life.* This faith was not tied to a date. It was tied to an outcome so broad, so far away, that no single Christmas could break it.

The second was a ruthless honesty about the present. Stockdale did not pretend that things were better than they were. Collins later wrote that he carried a mental image of Stockdale turning to the optimists and saying: *We're not getting out by Christmas; deal with it!* Stockdale looked at the brutal facts every day, and he built his life around them. He helped organize ways for the prisoners to communicate secretly, tapping coded messages through the walls. He helped draw up rules for how the men should resist, so that no prisoner had to work out alone what was expected of him. He kept people connected, which kept them alive.

Frankl described something similar from his own camp, though he used different words. He found that the prisoners who held up best were often those who had something to live *for*: a person waiting for them, a task unfinished, a book they intended to write. He liked to quote Nietzsche here, of all people: *He who has a why to live for can bear almost any how.* The *why* was not a date. It was a meaning. A meaning cannot be cancelled by a calendar.

Hold faith in the end of the story, and honesty about this chapter. You need both.

* * *

Most of us will never be prisoners of war. But many of us will spend some part of our lives in a long wait.

Waiting for a job after months of applications. Waiting for a visa. Waiting for a diagnosis, or a recovery. Waiting for a marriage proposal that keeps being postponed. Waiting for a family to accept a choice. Waiting for a debt to be paid off, a court case to finish, a child to come home.

And in these waits, it is very natural to do what the optimists did. *By the end of the month, I'll have heard back. By the summer, I'll be well. By her birthday, he'll have changed his mind. By next year, everything will be different.* We set dates because dates give the fog a shape. They make the waiting feel finite.

There is nothing wrong with planning by dates. A target date is a useful tool: *I will send ten applications by Friday. I will review my strategy at the end of March.* Those are dates you control. They are about your own actions.

The danger comes when the date becomes a prophecy about something you do not control. *I will have a job by March. She will*

come back by Eid. I will be cured by summer. These are not plans. They are appointments with the wind. And when the wind does not show up, the hope that was tied to the appointment takes the blow.

A deadline is a tool. A prophecy is a trap.

* * *

So how do you hold hope through a long wait without being broken by it? Here is what I have learned from Stockdale, from Frankl and from watching people I love go through their own long seasons.

Hope for the end of the story, not for a particular page. *I will work again. I will build a life I am glad to live. I will find people to love who love me back.* These hopes are wide enough that no single disappointment can kill them.

Put your dates on your actions, not on outcomes. You decide when you will apply, call, rest, review and try again. You do not decide when the answer comes.

Look at the brutal facts on a regular schedule. Once a week, perhaps, ask honestly: *What is actually true right now? What has changed? What has not?* Facing reality on purpose, at a set time, is much less frightening than having it ambush you at three in the morning.

Build meaning inside the wait, not only beyond it. Stockdale's men tapped messages through the walls. Frankl, sick with typhus in the camp, began rebuilding on scraps of paper the manuscript that had been taken from him. The wait is not an empty corridor between your old life and your real life. It is your life, right now. What can you learn, give or build inside it?

And do not wait alone. The tapping through the walls was not a small detail. Isolation turns waiting into despair faster than anything else. Find the people who will tap back.

* * *

There is a strange gift hidden in Stockdale's paradox, and I want to end with it.

When you stop tying your hope to a date, the hope becomes harder to break. That much is obvious. But something else happens too. You become free to notice the present: the small kindnesses, the unexpected openings, the people tapping through the walls. The optimists in Stockdale's prison spent so much of their attention on the next Christmas that they had little left for the cell they were actually in. Stockdale, by accepting the cell, could work inside it.

The archer does not know when the wind will drop. If she decides that it must drop by noon, and it does not, she may put her bow down in despair. But if she simply knows that winds change, that they always eventually change, she can keep her bow strung and her eyes open and draw again the moment the air goes still.

Faith in the end of the story. Honesty about this chapter. That is the kind of hope that brings people home.

For your quiver

Hope that sets a date with the universe will one day be stood up.

A deadline is a tool. A prophecy is a trap.

Hold faith in the end of the story, and honesty about this chapter.

Practice. Write down any hopes you are holding that have a date attached to an outcome you do not control. Rewrite each one in two parts: a wide hope for the end of the story, and a dated plan for your own next actions. Then choose one day each week when you will look at the brutal facts on purpose, and put it in your calendar.

Part Five: The archer

On living with all four: when the arrow misses, when love is the target, when to keep going and when to aim somewhere new

The result belongs in your story. It does not have to become the title of your life.

Chapter 14: The job that did not come

Three weeks after the email, Sana applied for two more positions. One sent a rejection within forty-eight hours, an automated message that did not even use her name. The other never replied at all.

There is a particular loneliness to looking for work. It happens mostly in silence, at a screen, late at night. The rejections arrive one by one, and each one is small enough that you feel you should not be so upset about it, and yet they pile up inside you like stones in a pocket. Other people do not see them. Often you do not tell anyone, because you are embarrassed, and because there is nothing anyone can do.

And in many families, a job is never only a job. It is money, of course. But it is also status, security, the answer to the question relatives ask at every gathering. It may be tied to marriage prospects, to a parent's pride, to the sacrifices that were made to pay for your education. When Sana was rejected, she did not only feel that she had failed. She felt, without anyone saying it, that she had let her family down.

If you are in a season like this, I want this chapter to sit beside you for a while. Not to cheer you up, but to help you think clearly at a time when clear thinking is hard.

* * *

Let me start with some good news, and it is real news, from careful research.

In 1998, the psychologists Daniel Gilbert, Timothy Wilson and their colleagues published a set of studies about how people predict their own feelings after bad events. They looked at a range of disappointments: the end of a romantic relationship, seeing a favored candidate lose an election, receiving negative feedback about one's personality. One of their studies involved young professors waiting to hear whether they would be given tenure, the permanent position that most academics spend years working toward. Another involved people turned down for a job they wanted.

Again and again, the same pattern appeared. People predicted that the bad event would make them miserable, and that the misery would last a long time. When the bad event actually happened, they felt bad, but less bad than they had predicted, and for less time. The professors who were denied tenure, for example, had predicted that they would be unhappy for years. Some years later, they were reporting happiness levels not far from those of colleagues who had been promoted.

Gilbert and Wilson's explanation is that we all have what they call a *psychological immune system*: a set of mental processes that help us recover from pain, find new meaning, notice new possibilities and make our peace with what happened. Like the body's immune system, it does its work in the background. And because we rarely see it working, we forget it is there. So when we imagine a future disappointment, we imagine the pain without imagining the recovery.

This does not mean that rejection does not hurt. It does. The first days can be very hard. But it does mean that the voice in your head saying *I will never get over this* is, on the evidence, probably wrong.

You are usually stronger than your forecast.

* * *

The second thing I want to say is about what a rejection actually tells you.

When you are turned down for a job, your mind immediately wants a reason. Not knowing is almost unbearable. So the mind supplies one, and the reason it supplies is usually the most painful available: *I wasn't good enough.*

But think about all the reasons a person might be rejected for a particular job.

There may have been a real gap in your skills or experience. Your application may have been weaker than it could have been, even if you are well qualified. There may have been stronger candidates; or equally strong ones, and someone had to be chosen. There may have been an internal candidate the company always intended to hire. The budget may have changed, or the role may have been redesigned. The interviewer may have had a bad day, or a personal preference, or a bias, conscious or not. There may have been a simple matter of timing; another candidate interviewed first, and set the standard. And there are almost always reasons you will never learn.

Out of all these possibilities, only the first two are really about you, and even those are about your application and your current skills, not your worth as a person.

So when the mind supplies its verdict, try supplying the whole list instead. Not to excuse yourself, and not to blame the company, but to restore the truth. A single rejection is a single closed door. It is not a map of the building.

A rejection tells you that one door closed. It does not map every door you can reach.

* * *

Now, there is real value in finding out which of those reasons applied, when you can. This is where effort comes back in, in its most useful form.

Some companies will give feedback if you ask. Many will not, often for legal reasons, and some will not reply at all. But it costs little to ask, politely and specifically. A good question is a narrow one: *Is there one thing that would have made my application stronger?* People find it much easier to answer one specific question than a vague request for "feedback."

You can also seek feedback from other places. A friend who works in the industry. A former manager. A career adviser. Someone who has hired people for similar roles. Show them your application. Practice an interview with them, and ask them to be honest, even unkind.

When feedback comes, it will sometimes sting. Let it. Feedback is information about your approach. It is not information about your value. The danger in a long job search is that these two things get confused, so that every rejection lowers not your estimate of your application, but your estimate of yourself.

Let feedback change your approach before rejection changes your estimate of your worth.

And sometimes, after you have asked everyone you can, you will still not know why. That is the hardest outcome, and also a very common one. In that case, I would suggest a rule that has helped me: *do not invent an explanation for what remains unknown.* Improve what you can see. Let the rest stay a question mark. A question mark is much lighter to carry than a false verdict.

* * *

What about the job search itself? Here, the lessons of the earlier chapters become practical.

Remember the woodcutter in Chapter 2. If you have sent out fifty applications in the same form and received nothing, the next step is not fifty more of the same. Stop, sharpen the axe, change something and then go again.

Remember the luck surface area from Chapter 4. Many jobs are filled, in part, through people: someone who knows someone, who mentioned a name, who forwarded a message. Applying through websites is necessary, but it is often the least lucky route. Talking to people in the field, showing your work in public, telling others what you are looking for, all of these widen the space where luck can find you.

Remember the drowned sailors of Chapter 5. When you see other people announcing their new jobs, you are seeing their votive tablets. You are not seeing their forty rejections.

Remember the four boxes of Chapter 7. A rejection is an outcome. It might come from a bad decision or a good one. Examine your process, not just the result.

And remember Stockdale. Put your dates on your actions, not on the outcome. *I will send five well-made applications this week. I will ask two people for feedback. I will review my approach at*

the end of the month. Those are promises you can keep. *I will have a job by March* is not.

* * *

There is one more thing that a long job search can teach, and it is the thing that changed Sana's story.

About two months after the first rejection, Sana sat down one evening and asked herself the question from Chapter 12. What had that famous company actually *stood for* in her imagination? What was she really hoping for, underneath the glass building and the lanyard?

She wrote down three things. Security: a salary that would let her help her family and stop worrying. Respect: doing serious, skilled work that people valued. And growth: learning quickly, from people who were better than her.

Then she noticed something. None of those three things lived only in that one company. In fact, she began to suspect that at a famous firm, a junior analyst might wait years before she was trusted with anything serious, while at a smaller firm she might be given real responsibility almost immediately.

So she widened her aim. She kept applying to large companies, but she also began looking at smaller ones that did serious work in her field. She asked one of the two former employees she had met over coffee, months earlier, whether she knew anyone at such firms. The woman did. A conversation led to an introduction, and an introduction led to an interview.

I am not going to tell you yet how it turned out, because that belongs to the last chapter. And I want to be clear: widening her aim was not a guarantee. It could have led to more rejections, and

for a while it did. What it gave her was more roads for the same hope to travel.

* * *

I want to end this chapter with a word about fairness, because not every job search is simply a matter of skill and luck.

Some people face barriers in hiring that have nothing to do with their ability: their name, their gender, their religion, their accent, their age, their disability, the neighborhood they come from. We saw evidence of this in Chapter 3. If you suspect that this is part of what you are facing, two things can be true at once.

It can be true that you should keep improving your applications, building your skills and widening your search, because those are things within your power.

And it can also be true that the barrier is wrong, that it is not your fault and that it is not only your problem to solve. You can seek out employers with better records. You can find organizations that support people in your position. You can, when you are in a position to do so, help change the rules for the next person. Effort that goes into making a system fairer is still effort. It is some of the most important effort there is.

* * *

If you are reading this in the middle of a season of rejection, let me say plainly what I would say if I were sitting next to you.

Your pain makes sense. You wanted something good, and you worked for it, and it did not come. You are allowed to grieve that.

But the email, or the silence, is not allowed to speak for your whole life. It is one result, from one place, at one time, for reasons you may never know. You are probably stronger than you feel to-

day. There is probably more room around you than you can see from where you are standing. And there are certainly doors you have not yet knocked on.

Sharpen the axe. Ask for feedback. Widen your aim. Rest when you need to. And then draw the bow again, not because the next arrow is guaranteed to land, but because the archer who keeps drawing is the only one who ever hits anything at all.

For your quiver

A rejection tells you that one door closed. It does not map every door you can reach.

Let feedback change your approach before rejection changes your estimate of your worth.

You are usually stronger than your forecast.

Do not invent an explanation for what remains unknown.

Practice. Write a one-page plan for the next month. Include one specific improvement you will make to your applications, one person you will ask for feedback, a manageable number of applications you will send each week and a date when you will review your approach. Then write down what the job you lost really stood for, and one other road toward that.

Chapter 15: The person we hoped to marry

Of all the stories in this book, this is the one I have been most careful with, because it is the one that hurts the most people most deeply.

Let me tell you about Yusuf. He is a composite, like Sana, built from many lives.

Yusuf met Amna at university. They were friends first, then more than friends, carefully and slowly, the way such things often happen when families and futures are involved. For four years they talked about the life they would build. They chose, half-jokingly, the names of children. They talked about which city they would live in. Yusuf took a second job in the evenings so that he could save, because he wanted to come to her family as a man who was ready. Every night, for four years, he prayed for her and for their future together. He believed, with a certainty he could not explain, that she was written for him.

Then, over the course of a year, something changed. Amna became quieter. She was slower to answer his messages. When he asked what was wrong, she said nothing was wrong. And one evening, in a café they had been going to since their second year, she told him, gently and with tears in her eyes, that she could not

marry him. She did not see her future with him. She was sorry. She had tried to feel what he felt, and she could not.

A year and a half later, Yusuf saw the wedding photographs.

* * *

I do not know why Amna changed. Neither does Yusuf, not fully. Perhaps she grew in a different direction. Perhaps her feelings were never as strong as his, and it took her time to admit it, even to herself. Perhaps there were reasons in her own life that he never saw. I am not going to invent her motives, because one of the hardest truths of this kind of loss is that the other person's heart is not ours to explain. It is theirs.

And that, I think, is where this chapter has to begin.

* * *

In every other chapter of this book, the archer has been aiming at a target. Targets do not have opinions. A job is filled by a decision, and decisions can be influenced, at least a little, by preparation and persistence. An exam is passed or failed according to fixed rules. Even luck, for all its unpredictability, has no will of its own.

Love is different. In love, the target is also an archer. She has her own bow, her own aim, her own wind and her own hopes. She is choosing too.

This means that love is the one goal in life where your effort must meet another person's freedom. And no amount of effort, devotion, sincerity or prayer can make that freedom disappear. You can be the most loving, faithful, hardworking, deserving person in the world, and the person you love can still, freely, choose a different life. Not because you failed. Because they are free.

In love, the target is also an archer.

This is hard to accept, because the old contract from Chapter 1 runs especially deep in love. We absorb it from every film and song. *If you love someone enough, if you are patient enough, if you prove yourself enough, they will love you back.* It is one of the most beautiful lies we tell, and one of the most dangerous.

It is dangerous for the person who is rejected, because it tells them that they were not loving enough, patient enough, good enough. And it can be dangerous for the person who is loved, too, because a person who believes that devotion creates a right to be loved back may find it very hard to hear the word *no*. Most people, thank God, can hear it. But we all know stories where devotion curdled into pressure, or worse, because someone believed that their effort had earned them a person.

Let me say it as plainly as I can. Devotion and effort do not create a right to another person's heart. They never did. Another person's freedom is not an obstacle to love. It is part of what makes love worth having. A love that could be compelled would not be love at all.

Another person's freedom is part of the reality love must respect.

* * *

Destiny plays a particular role in love, and it is worth looking at closely.

Many of us believe, or want to believe, that there is one person meant for us. The idea is ancient. In Plato's *Symposium*, written in Athens more than two thousand years ago, a group of friends at a dinner party take turns giving speeches about love.

The comic playwright Aristophanes tells a myth. Human beings, he says, were once round, double creatures, with four arms, four legs and two faces. They were so strong that the gods feared them, so Zeus split each of them in half. Ever since, every human being has wandered the earth searching for their other half. Love, Aristophanes says, is simply the name we give to the longing to be whole again.

It is a beautiful story, and it has shaped how people talk about love for twenty-four centuries. Soulmates. Other halves. *The one. She was written for me.*

But psychologists have found that how strongly we hold this kind of belief makes a real difference to how we handle love's difficulties.

In 1998, the psychologist C. Raymond Knee published a study of what he called *implicit theories of relationships*. Some people, he found, tend to hold what he called *destiny beliefs*: the idea that two people are either meant for each other or they are not, and that you can tell fairly early. Others tend to hold *growth beliefs*: the idea that good relationships are built and developed over time, through working on problems together. Later researchers have described these as "soulmate" beliefs and "work-it-out" beliefs.

Knee followed people's dating relationships over time. People with stronger destiny beliefs were more likely to cope with relationship problems by avoiding them, and the survival of their relationships depended more heavily on how satisfying things felt at the very beginning. People with stronger growth beliefs were more likely to deal with problems by working through them. And after a relationship ended, people with stronger growth beliefs were less likely to look back and say that it had seemed wrong

from the beginning. They did not rewrite the whole story because of its ending.

I find these findings deeply relevant to Yusuf, and to anyone who has lost a person they believed was destined for them. Because the belief *she was written for me* does two things after a loss, and both of them can hurt.

First, it can turn a painful loss into a total one. If there was only one person meant for me, and she has gone, then I have lost not just her but my only chance. I am, in Aristophanes' terms, permanently half.

Second, it can keep a person waiting. *If she is truly my destiny, she will come back.* So he waits. He watches her life from a distance. He turns down other possibilities, because they would be a betrayal of what was written. Months become years. This is the lazy argument from Chapter 8, applied to the heart, and it can cost someone the years in which a new love might have begun.

A shared future cannot be built from one person's certainty alone.

* * *

I want to be fair to destiny here. For many people, faith that their life is in good hands is exactly what allows them to survive a loss like this. *If she was not written for me, then someone else is, or something else is.* That can be a deeply healthy thought. It looks backward at the loss and makes peace with it, and it looks forward with openness rather than certainty. It does not say *I know who is written for me.* It says *I trust that my story is not over.*

The difference is the difference we saw in Chapter 8: destiny used to make peace with the past, versus destiny used to dictate

the future. *It was not meant to be* can bring peace. *She is meant to be, so I will wait* can bring years of pain.

* * *

There is another version of this story that I should mention, because in many parts of the world it is at least as common as Yusuf's.

Sometimes two people love each other completely, both want to marry and the marriage is prevented by something outside them both: families who refuse, differences of community or class or faith, a visa, money, distance, a parent's illness that ties one of them to another city. In this case, the target was not choosing differently. The target was willing. The wind was simply too strong.

This loss has its own particular grief, because it can carry anger as well as sorrow, and sometimes a lifelong *what if*. If this is your story, everything in Chapter 3 about barriers held in place by people applies to you. Some of those barriers can be moved, with time, patience, allies and courage. Some cannot. Knowing which is which is one of the hardest discernments a person can be asked to make, and you should not have to make it alone.

* * *

Whatever form your loss has taken, I want to say something about the grief itself.

When we love someone and imagine a life with them, we do not just hope for that life. We begin to *live* in it, in our minds. Yusuf had lived in that future for four years. He had walked through the rooms of the house they would share. He had held the children they had named. When Amna said no, he did not

only lose a person. He lost a future he had already begun to inhabit.

Some losses take away a future we had already begun to live in our minds.

The family therapist Pauline Boss has a name for one especially painful kind of grief: *ambiguous loss*. It is the loss of someone who is still alive but no longer present in the way they were. There is no funeral. There are no rituals. The world does not recognize what has happened, so it does not offer the support it would offer after a death. And yet something has died: a relationship, a shared future, a version of yourself.

If you are grieving a love that did not become a marriage, please know that your grief is real grief, and it deserves the time and care that any grief deserves. You do not have to be over it by a certain date. You do not have to pretend it was for the best. You do not have to call it a gift.

You do not have to call a loss a gift to build a life after it.

* * *

So what can a person in Yusuf's position actually do?

The first thing is to honor the other person's choice. This is painful, and it is also a kind of dignity. It means not pressuring, not pleading endlessly, not waiting outside her life for a change of heart. It means accepting that *no* is a complete answer. Strangely, many people find that this acceptance is the beginning of their own freedom. As long as you are fighting her choice, you are tied to it. When you honor it, you can begin to walk away.

The second is to protect yourself from the votive tablets. In the age of social media, it is possible to watch the life of the person you lost unfold in real time: the engagement, the wedding, the new home. Every picture is a fresh wound. Muting, unfollowing or simply not looking is not petty. It is medicine. You would not reopen a physical wound every morning to check whether it was healing.

The third is to separate the person from the needs. Ask yourself, when you are ready, what that relationship gave you or promised you. Companionship. Being truly known. Shared faith or values. Laughter. A partner in building a family. A sense of home. These needs were real, and they did not die when the relationship did. *She* cannot be replaced; no person can. But the needs she met, or might have met, can be met again, in time, in a different way, by different people. That is not betrayal. It is life continuing.

The fourth is to let people help you. Grief that is hidden grows heavier. Find the friend, the sibling, the counselor, the imam or priest or elder, the stranger in a support group, who will let you say it out loud.

And the fifth, when the time comes, and only when it comes, is to let your hope find a new direction. Not a new person to fixate on, and not a rushed replacement, but a reopening of the possibility that love may come again in a shape you have not yet imagined.

Hope should leave room for a future you have not yet imagined.

* * *

Yusuf did not do these things quickly. For months he did almost none of them. He checked her profile at night. He went back to

the café alone. He prayed for her to come back, and then, later, he prayed simply to stop hurting.

The change, when it came, was small. One night, instead of praying for Amna, he found himself praying *for* her: that she would be happy, that her marriage would be good, that she would be well. He was surprised to find he meant it. Something in his chest loosened. He did not stop loving her that night. But he stopped holding on to her, and his hands, for the first time in a long time, were free.

We will see where those hands led him in the last chapter. For now, I want to leave you with the truest sentence I know about love and effort.

You can give someone your whole heart. You cannot give them your will. And you cannot take theirs.

For your quiver

In love, the target is also an archer.

Another person's freedom is part of the reality love must respect.

A shared future cannot be built from one person's certainty alone.

You do not have to call a loss a gift to build a life after it.

Practice. If you are grieving a love that did not become the life you hoped for, write two lists. In the first, write what you loved about that person specifically. Let it be as long as it needs to be; this is part of grieving. In the second, write the needs that relationship met or promised to meet: companionship, being known, shared values, family, home. Read the second list slowly. These needs are still yours, and they are still worthy of being met.

Chapter 16: Hold on, or let go

On the twenty-ninth of October 1941, in the darkest year of the Second World War, Winston Churchill visited his old school, Harrow, and gave a short speech to the boys. One part of it has been quoted ever since, on posters, in locker rooms and in a thousand motivational talks:

Never give in, never give in, never, never, never, never—in nothing, great or small, large or petty—never give in…

Almost nobody quotes the rest of the sentence. Churchill went on: *…except to convictions of honour and good sense.*

I find that ending wonderful. The most famous speech about never giving up in the English language contains an exception clause. Even Churchill, at a moment when stubbornness was saving his country, knew that persistence was not the same thing as wisdom. There are times when honor and good sense tell you to stop.

The trouble is that nobody tells you exactly when those times are.

* * *

We are surrounded by two sets of advice that contradict each other completely, and both are delivered with total confidence.

Never give up. Winners never quit and quitters never win. Keep going. The moment you're ready to quit is usually the moment right before the miracle happens.

And: *Know when to walk away. Don't throw good money after bad. Let go of what isn't working. The definition of madness is doing the same thing and expecting different results.*

Both sets of sayings are true sometimes. Neither is true always. And most of the people who give this advice decide which version to give based on how things turned out, which, as we saw in Chapter 7, is exactly the wrong way to judge a decision. If you persisted and succeeded, you were a hero who never gave up. If you persisted and failed, you were a fool who could not let go. If you quit and something better came along, you were wise. If you quit and regretted it, you were weak.

So let us try to think about this more carefully than the posters do.

* * *

The first thing to know is that our minds are biased toward continuing, even when continuing makes no sense.

In 1985, the psychologists Hal Arkes and Catherine Blumer ran a simple and clever experiment at a university theater. People buying season tickets for a series of plays were randomly given one of three prices: full price, or one of two discounts. The tickets were otherwise identical. Then the researchers simply counted how many plays each group attended.

Over the first half of the season, the people who had paid full price went to significantly more plays than those who had received a discount.

Why? The money was already spent. It could not be recovered by attending, or lost by staying home. Rationally, the only question should have been: *do I want to see this play tonight?* But the people who had paid more felt they had more invested, and they did not want to "waste" it. They kept going to justify what they had already put in.

Economists call this the *sunk cost fallacy*. Money, time and effort that have already been spent are gone, whatever we do next. But we treat them as though they create a duty to continue. *I've already put five years into this degree. I've already spent so much on this business. I've already given this relationship so much of my life.* The more we have invested, the harder it becomes to stop, even when stopping is clearly right.

This is why I have come to distrust persistence when it is the only argument I have for continuing.

Before you call persistence a virtue, ask what it is preserving.

* * *

The second thing to know is that letting go of a goal, when it is truly out of reach, is not a sign of weakness. Often it is a sign of health.

The psychologist Carsten Wrosch and his colleagues have spent years studying what happens to people who face goals they cannot attain: a parent caring for a child with a serious illness who must give up career plans, an older person who can no longer do the work they once did, a young person whose path is suddenly blocked. In a set of studies published in 2003, they found that people who were better able to disengage from goals that had become unattainable tended to report better well-being: less distress, fewer symptoms of depression. And people who

could not only let go but also *re-engage*, finding new goals to put their energy into, tended to do better still.

These studies show associations, not strict causes, and they cannot tell any individual when to stop. But they do challenge the idea that the most admirable thing a person can ever do is refuse to let go. Sometimes the strongest thing is to release your grip on one goal so that your hands are free for another.

* * *

The third thing to know is that *give up* is not a single choice. It is several.

We usually talk as if there are only two options: continue or quit. But in real life, there are at least four.

You can *continue as you are*, doing the same thing, trusting that it will work given more time.

You can *change the method*, keeping the goal but trying a different way of getting there.

You can *pause*, setting the goal aside for a season while you recover, gather resources or deal with other things, with a plan to return.

And you can *leave the goal*, choosing to put your energy somewhere else entirely.

Many people who feel stuck between “never give up” and “let it go” are actually in need of the second or third option. They do not need to abandon the goal. They need to stop doing what is not working, or to rest.

* * *

So how do you know which one you need? There is no formula, and I will not pretend there is one. But there are some questions

that I have found help to clear the fog.

Is there evidence of progress? Not success, which may take a long time, but progress: getting closer, getting better, getting more interest, getting more specific feedback. If there is progress, even slow progress, that is a strong reason to continue. If there has been no progress at all for a long time, despite real effort, that is a strong reason at least to change the method.

Is the road hard, or is it closed? This is the most important distinction, and it is often blurred. A hard road is one where success is possible but difficult: you need more skill, more time, more attempts, more luck. A closed road is one where success is not possible, or not possible for you: a clear and final refusal from another person, an age limit, a rule that will not change, an opportunity that no longer exists. Hard roads need persistence. Closed roads need the courage to turn around. And the cruelest mistakes come from treating one as the other: giving up on a hard road too soon, or spending years pushing at a closed one.

A hard road and a closed road need two different kinds of courage.

What is it costing? Every goal has a price, not just in money, but in health, in relationships, in time that could have gone to other things, in the people who depend on you. Some prices are worth paying. Some are not. And it is often the people around you who can see the cost more clearly than you can. Ask them.

Is the value still alive? Sometimes, over years, we change. The goal that once expressed who we were no longer does. We keep pursuing it out of habit, or pride, or because we said we would. It is worth asking, honestly: *if I were starting today, knowing what I now know, would I choose this?*

Can the value be served another way? This is the question that opens the most doors, and I want to spend a moment on it.

* * *

The psychologist Angela Duckworth, whose research on grit made perseverance famous, makes an observation that is often missed by people who quote her. Our goals, she points out, are arranged in a kind of hierarchy. At the top is a single, deep, long-lasting purpose: what we care about most. Below it are many smaller goals, which are means to that end. The top of the hierarchy, she suggests, is worth holding onto stubbornly. The lower goals should be held more loosely. When one of them is blocked, it is often wise to swap it for another that serves the same purpose.

Let me give you an example. She is a composite.

Leila wanted to be a doctor for as long as she could remember. She applied to medical school three times, and three times she was rejected. Each time, she improved her application. Each time, the competition was fierce and the places few. After the third rejection, she sat with the question we have been asking: is this road hard, or is it closed?

She decided, after much grief and much advice, that for her, at least for now, it was closed. Her savings were gone. Her family needed her to work. The odds of a fourth attempt succeeding were real but small.

Then she asked the deeper question. Why did she want to be a doctor? When she was honest, the answer was not the title or the white coat. It was that she wanted to spend her life helping people who were ill and frightened, using science to do it.

Once she named that, she could see that medicine was one road to that place, but not the only one. She trained as a nurse. Years later, she specialized in caring for patients with cancer. She spends her days doing exactly what she once dreamed of doing: helping frightened, ill people, using science. She is not a doctor. She still feels a small ache when she thinks of the white coat. But the thing that made her want the white coat in the first place is alive in her every day.

Changing direction can protect the value that first made you begin.

Not every story ends this neatly, and I do not want to pretend otherwise. Some goals have no substitute that feels anywhere near as good. Some values can only be served in one specific way. Sometimes, when you leave a goal, you lose something that nothing else will ever fully replace. That is a real loss, and it deserves real grief.

But far more often than we expect, the thing we were really reaching for can be reached by another road.

Quit the road if you must. Keep the reason.

* * *

There is one more practice that I think helps more than any other, because it protects you from making this decision in your worst moment.

Decide in advance.

Before you begin a difficult goal, or at a calm moment along the way, write down a short review rule. What evidence would tell you to keep going as you are? What evidence would tell you to

change your method? What costs are you not willing to pay, whatever happens? And when will you review this: after how many attempts, how much time, how much money?

Then, when the hard moment comes, the night after the third rejection, the day the money runs low, you are not making the decision alone and exhausted. You are making it with your calmer, clearer self, who saw this moment coming and left you a note.

It will not make the decision painless. Nothing will. But it will make it yours, and not the decision of your fear, or your pride, or the money you have already spent.

* * *

Churchill was right. Never give in, never, never, never, except to convictions of honour and good sense.

The archer knows both halves of that sentence. There are days to keep drawing at a distant target through rain and wind, because she is getting closer and the target is worth it. And there are days to lower the bow, look around the field and recognize that her arrows would fly truer somewhere else. Neither choice is weakness. The only weakness is refusing to ask the question.

For your quiver

Before you call persistence a virtue, ask what it is preserving.

A hard road and a closed road need two different kinds of courage.

Changing direction can protect the value that first made you begin.

Quit the road if you must. Keep the reason.

Practice. For one goal you are unsure about, write a review rule. What evidence would tell you to continue? What evidence would tell you to change your method? What costs will you not accept? What deeper value does this goal serve, and what is one other road toward that value? Set a date to read this again, and keep it.

Chapter 17: The archer's discipline

In Japan, there is a form of archery called *kyudo*, "the way of the bow." It is practiced in quiet halls, with long asymmetrical bows of bamboo, and it has been taught for centuries as much as a discipline of the mind as a sport.

Students of kyudo learn the shot as a sequence of eight stages. The archer places her feet. She settles her body. She readies the bow. She raises it. She draws. She holds at full draw. She releases. And then comes the eighth stage, which is the one I want you to remember.

It is called *zanshin*, which can be translated as "the remaining mind" or "the continuing spirit." After the arrow has left the string, the archer does not drop her arms or turn away. She holds her posture, her attention and her composure, for a moment longer. The shot is not over when the arrow leaves. It is over when the archer has finished being present to it, whatever the arrow does.

Kyudo teachers have a saying: *a true shot is a hit*. They mean that if every stage of the shot is done rightly, the arrow tends to find its mark. But the practice does not focus on the target. It focuses on the shooting. The target is where the attention goes last, not first.

I have come to think that this is the closest thing I know to a picture of how to live with effort, luck, destiny and hope all at once. Everything that comes before the release is yours to do with all your heart. The release is a letting go. And what comes after, *zanshin*, is the part most of us were never taught: how to remain yourself, whole and attentive, while the arrow flies and lands wherever it lands.

This chapter is about turning the ideas in this book into a practice: something you can actually do, on an ordinary Tuesday, when you are facing something you want and cannot guarantee.

* * *

When I try to boil everything in this book down, I am left with four questions, one for each of the forces acting on the arrow, and a fifth for the archer herself. They are worth asking whenever you face a goal that matters, a decision you cannot be sure of or a disappointment you do not know what to do with.

The bow: What is mine to do?

This is the question of effort. What is the skill that actually decides this? What is the next concrete action? Where can I get feedback? What can I do this week that would change the odds, even a little? This question deserves your full energy. It is the part of the story that belongs to you.

The wind: What is not mine?

This is the question of luck and circumstance. What forces are acting on this that I did not choose and cannot control? Other people's decisions, the economy, timing, health, the ground I started from. Naming these does two things. It helps you prepare for them, and widen your luck surface where you can. And it

stops you from blaming yourself for things that were never in your hands.

The page: What story am I telling?

This is the question of destiny and meaning. When I think about this situation, what story is running in my head? Is it a verdict, *I am not good enough, it was never meant for me, nothing ever works out*? Is it a fantasy, *this is destined, it will surely come*? Am I using destiny to make peace with the past, or to excuse myself from the future? Can I add the words *so far*?

The breath: What am I hoping for, and what is my next step?

This is the question of hope and prayer. What direction is this hope pointing in, underneath the specific outcome? What is the value I am really reaching for? What is the main obstacle? What is one if-then plan? Is there more than one road? And if you pray, this is the place for it: to name what you want, to mark the edge of your power and to ask for the strength to do your part.

The archer: Who am I, apart from this result?

This is the fifth question, and it is the one that holds the others together. If this arrow misses, what will still be true about me? What will I still care about, still be able to do, still be worth? What will remain of my life that this result cannot touch?

The next useful step can be clear even while the final outcome remains uncertain.

* * *

Let me show you how differently these questions can play out, depending on the target.

When Sana asked them about her job search, the answers looked like this.

What is mine to do? A great deal. She could improve her interview answers with honest practice, ask for feedback, widen her search to smaller firms and reach out to the contacts she already had. The bow, in her case, was large.

What is not mine? The hiring decisions themselves, the number of positions available, the other candidates, the internal politics of companies she would never see, the economy. Also, she realized, the fact that she could not afford an unpaid internship, which had shaped her CV.

What story am I telling? She noticed she had been telling herself a verdict: *I'm not good enough for the places that matter.* She rewrote it: *So far, I have not got the job I wanted. I got to the final round of a very competitive process, and I do not know why I was not chosen.*

What am I hoping for, and what is my next step? Underneath the famous company, she was hoping for security, respect and growth. The main obstacle was her nerves in final interviews. Her if-then plan: *if I feel myself freezing, then I will pause, breathe and tell a short story about a real piece of work.* Her next step: three conversations with people at smaller firms by the end of the month.

Who am I, apart from this result? A person who works seriously, learns fast, loves her family and is good at what she does, whether or not a particular company recognizes it.

Now look at how the same questions played out for Yusuf, about Amna.

What is mine to do? Much less. He could not make her love him. He could be honest about his own feelings, which he had been. He could respect her decision. He could look after himself. He could choose what to do with his evenings, his attention, his social media, his grief.

What is not mine? Almost everything about the outcome. Her heart, her choices, her life. The bow, in his case, was very small, and the target was an archer.

What story am I telling? She was written for me, so my life is ruined. He came, slowly, to a different one: *I loved someone who did not choose me. That is one of the hardest things a person can live through. It does not mean I will never be loved.*

What am I hoping for, and what is my next step? For a long time, he was hoping for her to return. That hope had a single road, and it was closed. When he was ready, he found what lay underneath: companionship, being known, building a family with someone who chose him back. His next step was very small: to stop checking her profile, and to say yes the next time his friends invited him out.

Who am I, apart from this result? A man who is capable of loving faithfully and deeply. That capacity did not leave with her.

Notice how different the two cases are. In Sana's, the questions led to a list of actions. In Yusuf's, they led mostly to acceptance and to a very small first step. Both are right. The point of the questions is not always to produce more effort. It is to put effort exactly where it belongs, and nowhere else.

* * *

Some people like to have something they can write on. If you are one of them, here is a single page you can use for any goal or decision. I call it the archer's card.

At the top, write the *goal*: what you are aiming for, in one sentence.

Underneath, write the *value*: why it matters, what it is really about.

Then write *my next action*, with a date. Just one. The smallest real step.

Then *what I do not control*. Name the wind.

Then *the main obstacle*, and *if it appears, I will…*

Then *the help I need*, and from whom.

Then *another road*: one other way the same value could be served, if this one closes.

Then *if this fails, I will…* This one feels uncomfortable to write. Write it anyway.

A plan becomes more honest when it includes what you will do if it fails.

And finally, a *review date*, when you will look at this card again and ask whether to continue, change, pause or leave.

The card takes ten minutes to fill in, and it does two things at once. It makes you more serious about the effort, because the next action has a date. And it makes you less afraid of the outcome, because the failure already has a plan.

* * *

If you would like to practice these ideas more deliberately, here is a simple month you can try. It is not a program and it does not promise any particular result. It is just a way of living with these questions for four weeks, so that they become habits rather than ideas.

In the *first week*, choose one goal that matters to you and fill in an archer's card for it. Spend the week noticing where your energy goes. How much of it goes to the bow, the things that are yours to do? How much goes to worrying about the wind?

In the *second week*, sharpen one method. Find one source of honest feedback on how you are pursuing your goal, and change one thing in response to it. Think of the woodcutter.

In the *third week*, widen your luck surface. Tell three people what you are working on. Show your work somewhere it can be seen. Keep the luck log from Chapter 4: each evening, a line about what you did, what surprised you, good and bad, and who helped.

In the *fourth week*, review. Read your card and your log. Choose one change to keep, one thing to stop and one uncertainty to carry forward without forcing an answer.

Throughout the month, include rest. Include setbacks. Include days where nothing happens. Write down the bad surprises as carefully as the good ones. And above all, do not turn this into another test that you can pass or fail. The point of keeping small records is not to score yourself. It is to see your life more accurately than the large, dramatic stories that disappointment tells.

Small records can correct the large stories disappointment tells us.

Measure what helps you act more wisely, and leave the rest of your life room to breathe.

* * *

Let me return, at the end, to the eighth stage of the kyudo shot: *zanshin*, the remaining mind.

Most of us have been taught a great deal about the first seven stages, even if we never thought of them that way. We have been taught to prepare, to work, to aim, to try. Some of us have been taught to pray. What almost none of us were taught is what to do

in the moment after the release, when the arrow is gone and we are waiting, or when it has landed and it is not where we wanted.

Zanshin says: stay. Do not collapse. Do not turn away in shame or rush to the next arrow in panic. Hold your form. Watch with clear eyes where the arrow went. Feel whatever you feel. And remain yourself, an archer, whatever the target says.

Then, when you are ready, lower the bow, walk to the line and draw again.

For your quiver

The bow: what is mine to do? The wind: what is not mine? The page: what story am I telling? The breath: what am I hoping for, and what is my next step? The archer: who am I, apart from this result?

A plan becomes more honest when it includes what you will do if it fails.

Small records can correct the large stories disappointment tells us.

After the arrow leaves, the archer remains.

Practice. Fill in one archer's card this week for something you care about: the goal, the value, your next dated action, what you do not control, the main obstacle with an if-then plan, the help you need, another road, what you will do if it fails, and a review date. Keep it somewhere you will see it.

Chapter 18: A life larger than the target

A palliative care nurse in Australia named Bronnie Ware spent several years looking after people in the last weeks of their lives. She sat with them, listened to them and, eventually, wrote down what they told her about their regrets. She published her observations first in a blog post and then in a book, *The Top Five Regrets of the Dying*.

Two of the regrets she heard most often have stayed with me while I wrote this book, because they seem at first to pull in opposite directions.

The first was this: *I wish I'd had the courage to live a life true to myself, not the life others expected of me.* People regretted the dreams they had never even tried for. The roads they had not taken because they were afraid, or because someone else disapproved, or because the odds seemed too long.

The second was this: *I wish I hadn't worked so hard.* People regretted the years spent chasing results at the expense of everything else: their families, their friends, their health, their joy. Ware wrote that she heard this from every male patient she nursed.

So the dying regretted not trying hard enough for the things that mattered. And they regretted trying too hard for things that,

in the end, did not matter as much as they had thought.

At first this seems like a contradiction. I have come to believe it is the whole answer.

* * *

The research on regret points in the same direction. In the 1990s, the psychologists Thomas Gilovich and Victoria Medvec studied what people regret over different spans of time. In the short term, they found, people tend to regret their actions more: the thing they said, the risk that did not pay off, the decision that turned out badly. But over the long term, the pattern tends to reverse. Looking back across years or decades, people more often regret what they did *not* do: the chance not taken, the person not approached, the dream not attempted.

Later researchers have argued about how strong and universal this pattern is, as they should. But the core of it has held up well enough that I think it deserves a place in any honest answer to the question this book began with: *why try at all, if trying guarantees nothing?*

One answer is simply this. The arrow you release may miss. But the arrow you never release is the one that will follow you for the rest of your life.

The arrow that misses is a loss. The arrow never released becomes a question you carry.

* * *

And yet the second regret, *I wish I hadn't worked so hard*, warns us about the opposite danger. We can try for one thing so completely that we starve everything else. We can make one target

the measure of our whole life, so that when we hit it, we look around and find the rest of our life has gone quiet, and when we miss it, we find there is nothing else left standing.

Viktor Frankl, whose words have appeared several times in these pages, believed that human beings can find meaning in three broad ways. We can find it in what we create or do: our work, our deeds, what we give to the world. We can find it in what we experience and whom we love: beauty, truth, another human being. And we can find it in the attitude we take toward suffering we cannot avoid.

Notice that only the first of these depends very much on outcomes, and even there, the meaning is in the doing as much as in the result. Love does not depend on winning. The attitude we take toward suffering does not depend on succeeding. A person whose life rests on all three is like a table with three legs. If one leg is cut short by a lost job or a failed dream, the table tips, but it does not fall.

A person whose whole life rests on one outcome is a table with one leg.

You can give a goal your best without giving it your entire worth.

* * *

I promised you that I would tell you how the stories ended. They have not really ended, of course; nobody's story ends in the last chapter of someone else's book. But here is where I last left them.

Sana took the job at the smaller firm. It paid a little less than the famous company would have. Within six months, she was handling clients on her own. Within two years, she was leading a small project team, something she might have waited five or six

years to do in the glass building. She is good at her work, and she is respected for it, and she has been able to help her family in the way she hoped.

Sometimes, she still passes the glass building on the bus. When she does, there is a small sting first, and then, usually, something else: a kind of surprised gratitude for the road she ended up on. She does not know whether the other road would have been better. It might have been. She has stopped needing to know. *Who knows?* says the old man at the frontier, and she has learned to say it too.

Daniel, who got the job she wanted, did well there. For the first few months, it felt like the best thing that had ever happened to him. By the end of the first year, it felt like a job: some days wonderful, some days tedious, with a manager who was not always fair. In his second year, he was passed over for a promotion he had worked hard for and believed he deserved. He did not know why. He went home that night, sat in his kitchen and read the email twice, as though the words might rearrange themselves.

I tell you this not because I want Daniel to suffer, but because I want you to see that winning did not exempt him from the human condition. The arrow that hits does not end the shooting. There is always another target, another wind, another morning. Winners and losers in any single contest turn out to be the same people, at different moments in the same long life.

Omar found work after eight months, a reasonable job at a reasonable company. He still does not know whether declining that first offer was the right decision. His decision journal tells him that his reasoning was careful and his concerns were real. The result tells him it cost him eight hard months. He has made a

kind of peace with holding both. Some questions do not get answered. They get carried, and over time, they get lighter.

Leila is still a nurse. She still feels a small ache when she sees a doctor's white coat. And she still goes to work every day to do exactly what she wanted to do with her life.

And Yusuf.

It has been three years since the café. Yusuf has not married. Some evenings, especially around the date when he once planned to propose, he still thinks of Amna, and it still hurts. He no longer checks her profile. He moved to a new city for work, made friends there and found, to his surprise, that he loves teaching the young people who join his team. Recently, cautiously, he has begun getting to know someone. He does not know where it will lead. He is not calling it destiny. He is calling it a beginning.

His life is no longer arranged around an absence. That, I think, is the real recovery from a loss like his. Not forgetting. Not replacing. Just a life that has grown large enough to hold the loss inside it, instead of a loss so large that it holds the life.

* * *

These are invented people, and I have given them gentle endings, gentler perhaps than real life always gives. But I have tried to make the endings different from one another, because real endings are. One reached a goal by changing it. One reached a goal and found it was not the end of wanting. One is still carrying a question. One is living a different version of the same dream. One is still grieving and still living.

What they share is not an outcome. It is something more important. Each of them, in their own way, refused to let a single result become the title of their life.

The result belongs in your story. It does not have to become the title of your life.

* * *

So let me bring the four words back to the table one last time, the four words that started all of this.

Hard work is real. It is the bow, the part that belongs to you. It changes the odds, builds skill, creates places for luck to land and gives you something to say yes with when opportunity arrives. It deserves your full effort, aimed well and paced so you can sustain it. It does not deserve your entire worth.

Luck is real. It is the wind, blowing since the day you were born and still blowing now. It shapes the ground you start from and the openings that appear. It can be noticed, invited and prepared for, but never commanded. It explains much of what other people's success stories leave out, and much of why sincere people lose. It is not a verdict on anyone.

Destiny, whatever it is, is the page. If it is written, your effort and your prayers are written on it too, part of the ink and not outside it. Whether or not it is written, you can only read it backward. It is a beautiful word for making peace with the past, and a dangerous word for excusing yourself from the future.

Hope, and for many of us *prayer*, is the breath before the release. It names what we want, marks the edge of our power, steadies us and sends us back to work. At its healthiest, it is not a prediction but a direction; not a date set with the universe, but a faith in the end of the story and an honest look at this chapter.

They were never really in conflict. They only seemed to be, because each of us was trying to live on one of them alone.

* * *

The life I wish for you, after all this, is not a life in which every arrow hits. No such life exists, and I would be lying if I promised it.

It is a life in which you draw the bow with your whole heart, for things that are worth it. In which you know the wind when you feel it, and do not take it personally. In which you tell your story honestly, including the parts you did not choose. In which you hope in a way that can survive a missed target, and pray, if you pray, with your hands still ready to work. And in which, when an arrow misses, as some always will, you remain: whole, attentive, still yourself, still an archer.

A life can remain unfinished in its ambitions and still be full in its meaning.

For your quiver

The arrow that misses is a loss. The arrow never released becomes a question you carry.

You can give a goal your best without giving it your entire worth.

The result belongs in your story. It does not have to become the title of your life.

A life can remain unfinished in its ambitions and still be full in its meaning.

Practice. Write three short paragraphs. In the first, write what you will pursue next and why it matters to you. In the second, write how you will treat yourself and the people around you while you pursue it. In the third, write what will still be worth caring about in your life if this attempt fails. Keep the third paragraph somewhere safe. You may need to read it one day.

Epilogue: Why try?

We began with a question, and I promised you a careful answer. Here it is, as plainly as I can give it.

If hard work cannot guarantee the result, if luck can undo the best preparation, if destiny may already be written and if prayers are sometimes answered with a no, then why try at all?

Try because effort changes the odds. It was never a contract with the outcome, but it was never nothing either. No farmer believes that plowing guarantees rain. Every farmer plows, because an unplowed field guarantees there will be no harvest at all.

Try because work builds a place for luck to land. The wind can only carry arrows that have been released. The newspaper message is printed on page two for everyone; only the people who are looking up from their counting will see it.

Try because if your destiny is written, your effort is not outside it. It may be part of the ink. Chrysippus said so in Athens, and Umar said so at the edge of a plague. And whether or not anything is written, you cannot read the page before you live it. Nobody ever has.

Try because the arrow that misses is a loss you can grieve and recover from, while the arrow you never release becomes a question you carry for the rest of your life.

Try because of what the trying makes of you. The skills, the courage, the room you widen, the people you meet on the way, the self you discover when you want something badly enough to go after it. The company may keep the job. It does not get to keep what you built while trying to earn it.

Try because hope, at its deepest, was never a prediction. It was the certainty that something makes sense, regardless of how it turns out.

And try, finally, because the trying is the part that is yours. The outcome was never yours to own. The aim always was.

* * *

At the beginning of this book, I mentioned a song whose chorus confesses that all the trying, all that distance covered, came to nothing in the end. I understand why people sing it. I have felt it. On the night the email arrives, or the café conversation ends, or the scan comes back, it feels like the truest thing anyone has ever said.

But I do not believe it anymore.

It mattered. It mattered not because it guaranteed anything, but because it was real. You prepared, and the preparation became part of you. You loved, and the love was not wasted because it was not returned. You hoped, and the hope kept you walking through days that would otherwise have stopped you. You prayed, perhaps, and the prayer steadied your hands. None of it bought the result. All of it was yours.

In the end, it does matter. Not because of where the arrow landed, but because of who drew the bow.

* * *

I want to leave you with a picture.

It is early morning in a wide field. The grass is wet. Somewhere far down the field there is a target, small from this distance, and you are not sure you can reach it. You have missed it before. Some of your arrows are still lying in the grass where they fell.

You walk to the line. You set your feet. You feel the wind on your face, and you know you cannot stop it; you can only learn to read it. You do not know what is written about this arrow, and you will not know until it lands. You take a breath, and whether you send it upward or simply let it go into the air, it steadies you.

Then you draw. Not because the arrow is guaranteed to hit. Because you are an archer, and this is what archers do.

The wind is blowing. The page is open. The target is far away.

Breathe, and draw.

The lines worth keeping

An archer's quiver, gathered in one place: the lines from this book that readers may want to return to, copy down or pass on.

The bow: on hard work

Effort changes the odds. It does not sign a contract with the outcome.

No farmer has ever believed that plowing guarantees rain. Every farmer plows.

A result tells you what happened. It does not tell you what you are worth.

Hard work deserves respect, even when it does not receive applause.

Hard work is two different things wearing one coat: strain, and aim.

Persistence needs feedback as much as it needs courage.

A method deserves your loyalty only while it deserves your confidence.

Exhaustion is a cost, not a contribution.

A fair account of achievement includes the ground the ladder stood on.

Your starting point was luck. Your direction is not only luck.

Not everything called bad luck is luck. Some of it has an author.

The wind: on luck

Work does not summon luck. It builds a place for luck to land.

The wind can only carry arrows that have been released.

Preparation cannot create the accident. It decides whether the accident becomes an opportunity.

Luck often has a human face. Remember to thank it.

The drowned do not paint pictures.

Every success story has a sample size. Ask who was left outside it.

It does not take much wind to decide a contest between archers who are all excellent.

Social media is a wall of votive tablets. The drowned do not post.

The old man did not say it was good. He said it was not finished.

A single result contains wind. A pattern contains you.

We call it luck too early. Add two words: so far.

Judge the decision by what you knew, not by what the dice did.

An outcome is evidence to examine, not a verdict on the person who faced it.

A good decision can lose. A bad decision can win. Only one of them can be repeated on purpose.

The written page: on destiny

If your destiny is written, your effort may be part of the ink.

Nobody has ever read their destiny in advance. We only read it backward.

A caused action can still be a cause.

Destiny is a beautiful word for the past and a dangerous word for the future.

There is no version of destiny in which the bow draws itself.

A story can make the past feel inevitable without making the future predictable.

Maktub, it is written, is almost always said in the past tense.

The words we use for uncertainty turn, in time, into rules for how we live.

Taking responsibility begins with an honest account of the room you have to act.

A choice becomes clearer when its constraints are named.

Your room may be small. It is almost never zero.

Freedom is not only something to believe in. It is a room you can make larger.

The breath: on prayer and hope

Prayer is what effort sounds like when it reaches the edge of its power.

Every people that learned to pray also invented a proverb about working.

An unanswered prayer is not a verdict on the one who prayed.

Tie the camel. Then trust.

Fantasy rehearses the arrival. Hope rehearses the road.

Give your hope more than one road to travel.

Hope becomes practical when it can name a next step.

Hope is not a prediction. It is a direction.

Hope that sets a date with the universe will one day be stood up.

A deadline is a tool. A prophecy is a trap.

Hold faith in the end of the story, and honesty about this chapter.

The archer: on living with all four

A rejection tells you that one door closed. It does not map every door you can reach.

Let feedback change your approach before rejection changes your estimate of your worth.

You are usually stronger than your forecast.

Do not invent an explanation for what remains unknown.

In love, the target is also an archer.

Another person's freedom is part of the reality love must respect.

A shared future cannot be built from one person's certainty alone.

Some losses take away a future we had already begun to live in our minds.

You do not have to call a loss a gift to build a life after it.

Hope should leave room for a future you have not yet imagined.

Before you call persistence a virtue, ask what it is preserving.

A hard road and a closed road need two different kinds of courage.

Changing direction can protect the value that first made you begin.

Quit the road if you must. Keep the reason.

The next useful step can be clear even while the final outcome remains uncertain.

A plan becomes more honest when it includes what you will do if it fails.

Small records can correct the large stories disappointment tells us.

After the arrow leaves, the archer remains.

The arrow that misses is a loss. The arrow never released becomes a question you carry.

You can give a goal your best without giving it your entire worth.

The result belongs in your story. It does not have to become the title of your life.

A life can remain unfinished in its ambitions and still be full in its meaning.

In the end, it does matter. Not because of where the arrow landed, but because of who drew the bow.

Notes and sources

The research and history in this book come from the sources below. Where a study is described, I have tried to report its setting and its limits along with its findings. Quotations from older works are given in the wording of a standard English translation, or paraphrased where noted. Sana, Daniel, Omar, Yusuf, Amna and Leila are composites: their names are invented and their stories are built from many lives.

Introduction

The song is Linkin Park, "In the End," from the album *Hybrid Theory* (Warner Bros., 2000). Its chorus is described, not quoted.

The archer image is from Cicero, *De Finibus Bonorum et Malorum* (*On Ends*), Book III, section 22, where the Stoic speaker compares the wise person to someone aiming at a mark. The phrase "to be chosen, not to be desired" follows a public-domain English translation; the rest of the passage is paraphrased.

Chapter 1: The contract nobody signed

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Chapter 2: Sweat is not a strategy

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Chapter 3: The ground under the ladder

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meetings and talks to students. See also Alice Schroeder, *The Snowball: Warren Buffett and the Business of Life* (New York: Bantam, 2008).

Robert H. Frank, *Success and Luck: Good Fortune and the Myth of Meritocracy* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2016).

Chapter 4: Why luck loves the hardworking

On the history of "the harder I work, the luckier I get," see the Thomas Jefferson Encyclopedia at Monticello, which lists the Jefferson attribution as spurious, and the research published by Quote Investigator on the "great believer in luck" and "harder I practice" variants.

Alexander Fleming, "On the antibacterial action of cultures of a penicillium, with special reference to their use in the isolation of B. influenzae," *British Journal of Experimental Pathology* 10, no. 3 (1929): 226–236.

Louis Pasteur's remark, "Dans les champs de l'observation le hasard ne favorise que les esprits préparés," comes from his inaugural lecture at the new Faculty of Sciences in Lille, 7 December 1854.

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Chapter 5: The drowned do not paint pictures

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Chapter 6: The old man at the frontier

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Chapter 8: If it is written, why write?

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Muwatta of Imam Malik. Translations differ in wording.

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Chapter 9: Reading the page backward

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Chapter 10: The room you have to act

William James's diary entry of 30 April 1870 is printed in *The Letters of William James*, edited by Henry James (Boston: Atlantic Monthly Press, 1920), volume 1. See also Robert D. Richardson, *William James: In the Maelstrom of American Modernism* (Boston: Houghton Mifflin, 2006).

Robert M. Sapolsky, *Determined: A Science of Life Without Free Will* (New York: Penguin Press, 2023).

Viktor E. Frankl, *Man's Search for Meaning* (Boston: Beacon Press). The book first appeared in German in 1946 and in English in 1959.

Chapter 11: Trust, and tie the camel

Aesop, "Hercules and the Waggoner," in many public-domain collections of the fables.

The saying about the camel is recorded in *Jami' at-Tirmidhi*, hadith 2517. It is graded *hasan* by several hadith scholars; others have questioned its chain of transmission. The saying "Nothing turns back the decree except supplication" is

in *Jami' at-Tirmidhi*, hadith 2139, and is likewise graded differently by different scholars.

The Spanish proverb "A Dios rogando y con el mazo dando" is usually explained through the story of a carter and a saint. *Ora et labora* is a traditional summary of the Benedictine way of life rather than a phrase from the Rule of Saint Benedict itself.

On the history of the Serenity Prayer, see Elisabeth Sifton, *The Serenity Prayer: Faith and Politics in Times of Peace and War* (New York: W. W. Norton, 2003). Niebuhr's original wording differs slightly from the popular version given in the text.

Chapter 12: The thing with feathers

Hesiod, *Works and Days*, the story of Pandora. The "box" comes from Erasmus's sixteenth-century Latin rendering of the Greek *pithos*, a storage jar.

Friedrich Nietzsche, *Human, All Too Human* (1878), section 71. The passage is paraphrased.

Emily Dickinson, the poem beginning "'Hope' is the thing with feathers," first published in 1891, after her death.

C. R. Snyder and colleagues, "The will and the ways: Development and validation of an individual-differences measure of hope," *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology* 60, no. 4 (1991): 570–585; and C. R. Snyder, "Hope theory: Rainbows in the mind," *Psychological Inquiry* 13, no. 4 (2002): 249–275.

Gabriele Oettingen and Doris Mayer, "The motivating function of thinking about the future: Expectations versus fantasies," *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology* 83, no. 5 (2002): 1198–1212; and Gabriele Oettingen, *Rethinking Positive Thinking: Inside the New Science of Motivation* (New York: Current, 2014).

G. Wang, Y. Wang and X. Gai, "A meta-analysis of the effects of mental contrasting with implementation intentions on goal attainment," *Frontiers in Psychology* 12 (2021): 565202.

Václav Havel, *Disturbing the Peace: A Conversation with Karel Hvížďala*, translated by Paul Wilson (New York: Alfred A. Knopf, 1990).

Chapter 13: The optimists who did not come home

Jim Collins, *Good to Great: Why Some Companies Make the Leap… and Others Don't* (New York: HarperBusiness, 2001), chapter 4. The quotations from Stockdale follow the text published on Collins's website under "The Stockdale Paradox." See also Jim and Sybil Stockdale, *In Love and War* (New York: Harper & Row, 1984).

The accounts of the death rate between Christmas 1944 and New Year 1945, and of Frankl's fellow prisoner who dreamed of the thirtieth of March, are in Part One of Frankl's *Man's Search for Meaning*. Frankl quotes Nietzsche's line about the "why" and the "how" in the same book.

Chapter 14: The job that did not come

Daniel T. Gilbert, Elizabeth C. Pinel, Timothy D. Wilson, Stephen J. Blumberg and Thalia P. Wheatley, "Immune neglect: A source of durability bias in affective forecasting," *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology* 75, no. 3 (1998): 617–638.

Chapter 15: The person we hoped to marry

Aristophanes' speech is in Plato's *Symposium*, 189c–193d.

C. Raymond Knee, "Implicit theories of relationships: Assessment and prediction of romantic relationship initiation, coping, and longevity," *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology* 74, no. 2 (1998): 360–370. The terms "soulmate" and "work-it-out" beliefs come from Renae Franiuk, Dov Cohen and Eva M. Pomerantz, "Implicit theories of relationships: Implications for relationship satisfaction and longevity," *Personal Relationships* 9, no. 4 (2002): 345–367.

Pauline Boss, *Ambiguous Loss: Learning to Live with Unresolved Grief* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1999).

Chapter 16: Hold on, or let go

Winston Churchill, speech at Harrow School, 29 October 1941.

Hal R. Arkes and Catherine Blumer, "The psychology of sunk cost," *Organizational Behavior and Human Decision Processes* 35, no. 1 (1985): 124–140.

Carsten Wrosch, Michael F. Scheier, Gregory E. Miller, Richard Schulz and Charles S. Carver, "Adaptive self-regulation of unattainable goals: Goal disengagement, goal

reengagement, and subjective well-being," *Personality and Social Psychology Bulletin* 29, no. 12 (2003): 1494–1508.

Angela Duckworth, *Grit: The Power of Passion and Perseverance* (New York: Scribner, 2016), on the hierarchy of goals.

Chapter 17: The archer's discipline

The eight stages of the shot (*shaho hassetsu*) and the saying *seisha hitchu*, "a true shot is a hit," are part of standard kyudo teaching in Japan.

Chapter 18: A life larger than the target

Bronnie Ware, *The Top Five Regrets of the Dying* (2011; Carlsbad, CA: Hay House, 2012).

Thomas Gilovich and Victoria Husted Medvec, "The experience of regret: What, when, and why," *Psychological Review* 102, no. 2 (1995): 379–395. For the debate that followed, see Thomas Gilovich, Victoria Husted Medvec and Daniel Kahneman, "Varieties of regret: A debate and partial resolution," *Psychological Review* 105, no. 3 (1998): 602–605.

Frankl's three ways of finding meaning are described in Part Two of *Man's Search for Meaning*.

Further reading

Robert H. Frank, *Success and Luck* (2016), on fortune and merit. Oliver Burkeman, *Four Thousand Weeks: Time Management for Mortals* (2021), on finitude and the wish to control life. Christian Busch, *The Serendipity Mindset* (2020), on noticing and using unexpected openings. Angela Duckworth, *Grit* (2016), on perseverance, read alongside the research on deliberate practice in Chapter 2. Robert Sapolsky, *Determined* (2023), for the strongest modern case against free will.

A small request

If this book helped you, even a little, there is one thing you could do that would help it reach someone else who needs it. Leave an honest review wherever you bought it, or pass it to a friend who is standing in their own field right now, looking at the place where their arrow should have landed.

Most people who are struggling with these questions do not go looking for a book about them. They find one because somebody they trust put it in their hands.

About the author

Muhammad Waqas has spent years thinking about four ideas that people build their lives on, hard work, luck, destiny and hope, and about why they so often seem to contradict each other. He noticed, many times, that when he worked hard his luck seemed to improve. He also watched hardworking, hopeful people lose the things they wanted most. *The Archer and the Wind* is his attempt to make sense of both.